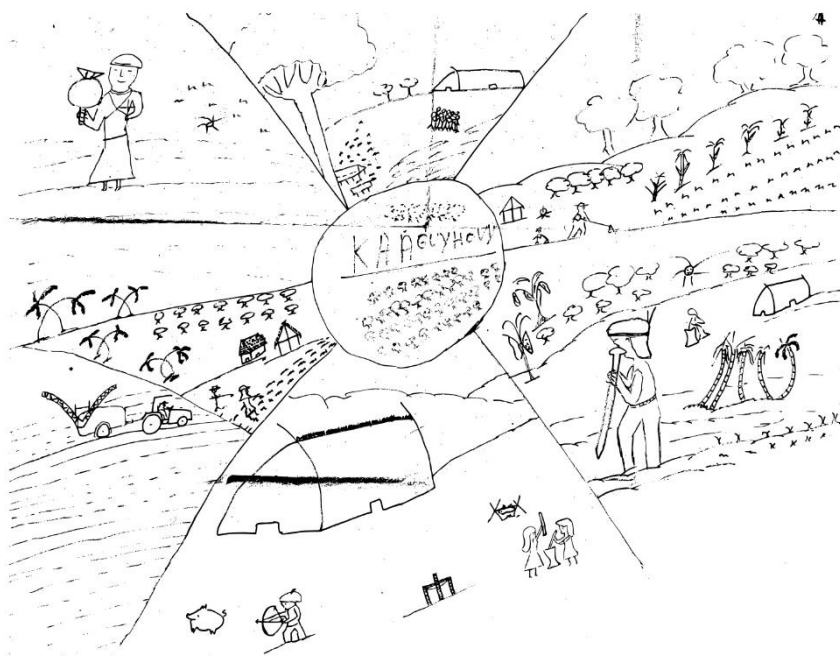


Translator's Note

This is an English translation of *Tecnologias Espirituais: Reza, Roça e Sustentabilidade entre os Kaiowá e Guarani*, by Anastácio Peralta, originally published in Portuguese by Pedro & João Editores (São Carlos, 2025). It was produced with the assistance of an AI language model (Claude, Anthropic) at a reader's request, and is not an official or publisher-authorized translation.

Passages originally recorded in the Guarani language — including direct oral testimony from community members — have been left untranslated and appear here exactly as in the original, since machine translation of Guarani is unreliable. Portuguese-language text, including the surrounding narration and framing of those testimonies, has been translated into English. Bibliographic references are left in their original language and form, following standard academic citation practice. Pagination differs from the Portuguese original because English text does not occupy the same space as Portuguese; the table of contents below reflects this English edition's own pagination.



2

Anastácio Peralta

**Spiritual Technologies:
Prayer, Cultivated Fields, and
Sustainability among the Kaiowá and
Guarani**



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Anastácio Peralta

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“Mato Grosso do Sul, where an ox is worth more than a child, where a soybean plant is worth more than a cedar tree” (Anastácio Peralta)



Acknowledgments

To Tupã, for his creative intelligence that transforms everything that inhabits the planet. To my parents, who conceived the spirit that gave rise to me. To my traditional teachers and doctors, the Nhanderu and Nhandesy. To the members of the Panambizinho Indigenous Land, who welcomed me as a son of this tekoha. To the partners in these projects. To the women teachers and scholars who, in difficult times, helped me not lose heart on the path in search of new knowledge. To the teachers and scholars of the world of letters who guided me, encouraged me, and made it possible for me to walk this far. To my scribe, who helps me organize the codes of writing. To all the people who, directly or indirectly, supported me and contributed so that my studies and the knowledge of my people might be recognized in the world of academia.

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Agwyjwevete pe' eme

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About the Author

Kwarahy Rendyju, Ava Yvy Poty: radiant sun, flower of the earth

I am Anastácio Peralta, son of Conceição Medina and dona Bonifácia Peralta, born in Dourados, Mato Grosso do Sul, in the village of Te'ýikue, municipality of Caarapó, on May 2, 1960. Currently 61 years old, I am single, a teacher, a Kaiowá farmer, a student, a researcher, a master's graduate, a doctoral candidate, and a witness to the social changes that have taken place among my people since the times when we lived free in our territory. Along this trajectory I became an observer of confinement to reservations, of expulsion to the back lots of ranches and cities, of the search for traditional territories, of the violence suffered at the hands of governments, and of the violence suffered from the anti-indigenous population of the State.

Over the course of my sixty-one years of life, as the son of this couple who spent little time with me, since my father passed away while I was still in early childhood, I grew up in the village of Caarapó and on the ranches in the surrounding area. I started school past the age of eight, but I learned little because I was afraid and did not understand what the teachers said, and besides, from a very young age I already had to go to work, so school at that time was something quite distant from my reality.

In this social context I did not remain in school. I helped care for the settlers' children, tend animals, and plant and harvest in my family's fields. I entered a stable relationship while still young and became father to Devanildo Ramires Peralta. To support my family, I worked handling cattle on a ranch, and later went to work in cattle drives, crossing the state from north to south, from west to east, through rain, cold, or scorching sun.

On the cattle drive I was cook and companion to the other members. But I dreamed about the children who walked alongside the rural schools we passed by. I dreamed of one day becoming a teacher, an educator. Time went by, and in the 1990s I went to live in the village of Dourados. I worked as a bagger at the company Cotrijui, and during this period I had the joy of finding, and being found by, the Missionary Indigenous Council (CIMI), where I formed a beautiful friendship with Hilário Paulos, who encouraged me in this dream of becoming an educator.

I studied through the Brazilian Literacy Movement (Mobral) and through Youth and Adult Education (EJA), where I had the opportunity to contribute by assisting in meetings and reflections on the difficult moment faced by the Jaguapiru and Bororó reservations, in the municipality of Dourados, in the face of a strong wave of suicides, which I called the death industry caused by the colonialist system.

I was also, for many years, quite involved in organizing the Aty Guasu movements (the Great Assembly of the Guarani and Kaiowá Peoples), and after many conversations and reflections with the male and female prayer leaders, I began turning my senses toward seeking to understand why we lived and suffered discrimination. It was at that moment that I stopped accepting and began questioning everything that involved me and involved my people. So, at this point in my life, I began to turn toward my people, to observe, feel, and contemplate our whole life and our existence. I reflected that even after so much theft, so much genocide, so much violence, we remain alive, resisting and existing, and, most of the time, with joy and hope.

With this idea in mind and in my heart, in 1994 I began the project “Teko Joja,” in the village of Dourados, whose objective was to delve into theories and practices of good living for our

indigenous people, cultivating ideas about fields, crops, and sustainability through Kaiowá and Guarani eyes. This journey of learning and reflection alongside my people led me, in 1999, to join the Ara Verá project - a Normal-level Secondary Course for the Training of Guarani and Kaiowá Teachers, after taking placement exams to test out of primary school (elementary education). This project was born from the struggle of the Kaiowá and Guarani, from the demands that existed at that moment.

It was in this phase of my life that I found another love, with whom I built a relationship and had a beautiful daughter, Camila Snarde Peralta, daughter of Braulina Snarde, a great companion in the struggle for school education, for the women's movement, and for our territories, which the government still does not recognize despite the studies. However, life goes on its course, and we separated. In 2001 I took part in the Coordination of Indigenous Affairs, in the Popular Government of the Municipality of Dourados, and in 2008 I became a member of the National Commission on Indigenist Policy - CNPI, of the Ministry of Justice.

Thus, during this time of walking the path, of studies supported by the male and female missionaries of CIMI, together with the brothers and sisters, companions of the Workers' Party (PT), whom I believe to be allies in the indigenous cause, I had the opportunity to be an active member of the working group that helped shape the city of Dourados under the government of then-mayor Laerte Tetila, of the Workers' Party (PT). In that administration I worked in the Secretariat of Government, was an advisor to the training group of the Ará Verá Project through the State Secretariat of Education, was an employee of FUNAI, worked in the sector of Agriculture and Local Development; and also had the opportunity to contribute as advisor and consultant

to the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), of the United Nations (UN).

In 2008, I entered the Indigenous Intercultural Faculty (FAIND), an achievement won through much struggle by all the Kaiowá and Guarani, together with so many friends who continue the fight for FAIND to truly be the space where our knowledge receives its due value and is not usurped by the *karaí*, since the non-indigenous logic is to turn it into merchandise.

I graduated with great difficulty, being part of the movement and having, on countless occasions, to leave classes and go to the struggle in local, national, and international mobilizations. This delayed things somewhat, but I completed my degree with great care, in the Human Sciences track of the Teko Arandu Indigenous Intercultural Teaching Degree program.

With great joy I had the opportunity to contribute, on this journey of mine, as a speaker at various state and municipal elementary and secondary schools and at universities throughout Brazil, and even at the European Parliament, where, besides learning and teaching, I used the space to denounce the injustices we live through. I have taken part in several audiovisual documentaries, such as: “Sementes de sonhos” (2009), “À sombra de um delírio verde” (2010), and Yvy Poty – Flores da Terra (2018).

I also took part in various training courses, such as: political and social training, solidarity economy, permaculture courses, experiential learning, and project management; with the aim of exchanging knowledge about our spirituality, fish farming, horticulture, and the management of Agroforestry Systems (SAFs), among many others that were quite important for building connections among allies.

I ran as a candidate for federal deputy in 2014 for Mato Grosso do Sul (MS), for the PT, and was not elected. I received 2,622 votes (0.21%) in the coalition “Mato Grosso do Sul com a força de todos” (PT, PR, PDT, PROS, PTC, PCdoB, PTB, PSDC). A few months after the election, I left the party because I disagreed with the thinking of the majority members of the Party in Dourados and in the state of Mato Grosso do Sul.

Today I live in the Tekoha Panambizinho, where I was adopted by my people as an heir-son of the struggle and the reconquest of this land. I have been here since 2010, where I have sought to understand the local cosmovision. Together with the community, I have sought partnerships and alliances so that we might jointly think through and carry out projects of self-sustainability and territorial self-management.

In this way, in this tekoha, I have supported the school, at times as an educator, at times as an education volunteer, in addition to working on building a space of free education, which is referred to by the community as the Free University of Indigenous Peoples and for Indigenous Peoples. We seek alliances with people who fight in defense of Mother Earth and who believe in the pedagogy of nature, so that this place may be built by many hands, so that the university may be able to function freely, without dependence on the State's education systems. May it be from indigenous to indigenous, and intercultural, in the exchange of knowledge among peoples who fight for and defend the diversity of life.

In 2019 I entered the master's program, after receiving encouragement from friends and refusing to accept the way the surrounding society treats me and treats my people. I thus decided to research and study more, so that I could better understand what this perverse system thinks of and has in store for me and for all the descendants of my people; because, being

prepared, I can engage in dialogue on equal terms, and I can better defend my people's way of being and living, which is not static and which has been harmed ever since the colonizers invaded our territories. This thesis was defended in the master's program in Education and Territoriality at the Federal University of Grande Dourados-UFGD, under the supervision of professor Dr. Laura Jane Gislotti. These reflections are now published in book form by the Graduate Program in Geography at UFGD, where I am currently pursuing my doctorate.

I wrote this work in the midst of the Covid-19 pandemic, a product of this perverse and selfish system, which has caused the death of many people, and this saddens me greatly. Thus, becoming a master's graduate at a historical moment of such relevance is a way of seeking the means to make myself visible in a society that does not see us, that exploits us, and that rejects our history, our language, and our right to have our sacred places, the territories of Ñanderu Guasu and its flowers.

I am Kwarahy Rendyju, Ava Yvy Poty, I am radiant sun, flower of the earth, born to admire and contemplate the beauties of the Creator, and with great joy and satisfaction, I invite you, readers, to walk together with me and feel my emotions and sensations.

Presentation

This book records and seeks to understand the spiritual technologies used by the Kaiowá and Guarani, which I define as the negotiations carried out between human and non-human beings in rituals and ceremonies performed for the planting, harvesting, and consumption of certain foods cultivated by the Kaiowá and Guarani peoples.

The Tekoha Where I Live, Dwell, and Exist: Panambizinho Indigenous Land

The Panambizinho Indigenous Land (TI), at the time of colonization, was distributed among the immigrants who came from various parts of the country. However, my kinspeople, who were being taken to the Dourados and Douradina reservations, resisted the system, causing discomfort at the time to the governments and to the new “owners” of the land. The State, believing that at some point the indigenous people would integrate into the surrounding non-indigenous society, decided that the Aquino, Concianza, and Pedro family groups would remain in the Panambizinho region, occupying 60 hectares of land.

Thus, these families found themselves hemmed in among the karaí, working as laborers clearing land and in the fields, but they always maintained their spirit of belonging, praying for more than 60 years, according to stories heard during home visits. Dona Odalicia, now passed on, told me that: *“My father and I and everyone who lived here, we prayed hard to Ñanderu¹, to the Hexakáry², to get our tekoha back”*. This story is still repeated today

1 Our father.

2 Spiritual leader, seer

by elder men and women and children connected to these family lineages.

After so many prayers, anthropological studies, and struggle against the governments, in 2004, under the government of President Fernando Henrique Cardoso, official recognition was won for the area called Yvy Akāndiré, corresponding to 1,272 hectares, which, according to what the elders tell, is part of the great Tekoha Guasu³. It was the spiritual struggle that secured the reconquest of this territory for them. However, they received this land deforested into pastures, with a few structures such as tanks, a pig shed, and some dwellings, but with almost no natural wealth remaining. The forest that had once been present in the region no longer existed.

During this period, amid the development of policy for indigenous school education, in keeping with this community's aspirations, the municipality's first indigenous school emerged, which came to be called the Pai Chiquito - Chiquito Pedro Indigenous School, in the Panambizinho Indigenous Land. Also emerging, through Ara Verá⁴ students Arnaldo and Misael, were many questions regarding the territory, its customs, its culture, its spirituality. Thus, these two residents of Panambizinho were the first indigenous people to begin writing the history of this territory, since before, it was only the karaí who wrote it.

And so, observing the wounded, sorrowful, bare land that would not offer them conditions for a long life, these two researchers from Panambizinho sought partnerships and also pursued the implementation of the public policies offered by governments and partner organizations (See appendix 1).

3 Greater Kaiowá and Guaraní territory.

4 Normal Course at Secondary Level for the Training of Guaraní and Kaiowá Teachers.

All of these projects brought people together in their design and execution; however, much as they answered a wish of the population, many mistakes occurred in their development, since most of the indigenous people did not take ownership of the techniques offered and did not use the goods made and/or produced. As a result, the investments made were substantial in quantity, but very little bore fruit.

Today the community has nearly 90% of its land under monoculture production, such as soybeans and corn, all transgenic, grown under an agreement made between the landowners and the Terena people of the Dourados village, to whom they pass on, per harvest, amounts equivalent to the production. According to Mrs. Fineida Aquino Concianza, "it's what we have to give our children! Better conditions for food, clothing, among other things" (Fineida; Panambizinho).

Thus, after we recovered the land, which we received with joy, with much singing and dancing, we realized that it came to us sick. It was entirely degraded, its plant cover made up only of colônião and brachiaria grasses. This is one of the reasons I hold responsible for leading many Panambizinho families to abandon the system of communal cultivated fields, because for many years they lived in a space that did not offer adequate conditions for the Kaiowá to reproduce their traditional way of being and living.

The degradation of our land was brought about by the ignorant way in which the karaí (non-indigenous people) managed the land, first through the excavation of the soil for large-scale ceramic production, such as roof tiles and bricks. Afterward came cattle ranching and the monoculture of soybeans and corn, which caused the land to be trampled and poisoned. The soil is now so compacted that subsoiling⁵ has

become necessary for the land to become fit for planting once again.

This situation means that many families, even today, continue to depend on the federal government's basic food baskets, which have been provided to this village since 1995. It is a very complicated situation, since the food offered is not as healthy as our traditional diet, given that the foods making up the basic food basket are always industrialized and ultra-processed. Often, these foods cause illness among my people, such as high cholesterol and diabetes, illnesses that are highly prevalent in the villages of Dourados.

Panambizinho is also served by the CRAS (Reference Center for Social Assistance), with weekly appointments, and by medical care twice a week provided by a multidisciplinary team.

Today Panambizinho, the little butterfly, flies high in search of new air to live...

Tape porã: the beautiful walk of research thought, felt, and built on the ground of the territory

This research was a continuation of my undergraduate thesis carried out in the Teko Arandu Indigenous Intercultural Teacher Training Program, at the Faculdade Intercultural Indígena, with the aim of continuing the reflections on sustainability, good living, seeds, land, and spiritual technology among the Guarani and Kaiowá.

To guide the methodological procedure, I drew on the work of indigenous scholars who had lived through analogous situations in their own research contexts, as was the case with

5 This is a technique used to loosen the soil layers so as to reduce compaction, promote tillage, and thus facilitate rooting, water penetration, and soil aeration.

Izaque João (2011), João Paulo Barreto (2013), Tonico Benites (2014), Eliel Benites (2014, 2020), Gileandro Barbosa Pedro (2020), Sônia Pavão (2021), Marcilene Lescano (2021), among other works produced by indigenous researchers.

At the outset, I did readings aimed at guiding the conduct of the fieldwork, focusing on indigenous authors, with the intent of disciplining the eye and the ear, in order to make the most of the ethnographic record and of the dialogue with the participants who generously contributed to the construction of this research.

● Odarícia Concianza (in memoriam).



As I am an indigenous researcher, researching my own life setting, a series of resources were mobilized that gave me access to routine situations, experienced in the day-to-day life of the community, which facilitated my reflections and dialogues. In this sense, the fieldwork was structured in two movements, where in the first, observation was carried out on a participant basis, taking part in and recording the rituals, ceremonies,

baptism celebrations, and the planting and harvesting of foods, such as white corn, in the greater Dourados region, covering the villages of Panambizinho, Panambi, and the Laranjeira Nhanderu land reclamation. Then, in the second moment, I drew on the wisdom and spiritual understanding of the spiritual and political leaders of my people, and so I selected the following interviewees, who are the intellectuals who hold all of the ancestrally systematized indigenous knowledge: Dona Odarícia, as she is known through her history, appears as Alice Pedro on her identity document, the RG. Wife of Lauro Concianza. Ñandesy prayer leader. She was born on August 20, 1920 and passed away on December 6, 2015, at the age of 95, in the Tekoha Panambizinho, municipality of Dourados. She raised her children through great struggle, on the 60 hectares of land, leaving much of her knowledge recorded in various books and publications about this tekoha. She gave us an immense legacy of teachings and examples. She is deeply missed!

● Nailton Aquino, 78 years old.



Second son of Paulito Aquino, singer of ghahu and kotyhu. Born on April 5, 1944, in Kaiowá territory, he lived his youth working on farms in the region, started a family, was widowed with his children still young, remarried, this time to his current wife, Mrs. Noêmia, with whom he had two children. He lives in Panambizinho, municipality of Dourados.

● Nelson Concianza, 90 years old.



Eldest son of Lauro Concianza and Odarícia Pedro. Married to Rosalina Aquino. Keeper of the crosses, prayer leader Ñanderu. He was born in the village of Panambi, on May 3, 1932. His life was guided by work alongside his community, he worked on farms in the region, married Mrs. Rosalina and had several sons and daughters. He suffers from the aftereffects of a stroke, but continues to teach his descendants the importance of the crosses, the prayers, and the songs. He lives today with his family in Panambizinho, municipality of Dourados.

● Jairo Barbosa, 84 years old



Son-in-law of Paulito Aquino. Native of Panambi Lagoa Rica. Ñanderu prayer leader and currently responsible for the Jerosy Puku. He was born in Saverá, in the Tey'ikwe indigenous reservation, municipality of Caarapó. He worked for many years on farms, passing through several states of the federation, including alongside the Maxacali people, in Minas Gerais, a place he dreams of returning to. He started a family, was widowed with young children, and raised them, teaching them his knowledge, and after some years decided to marry again. He went to live in Laranjeira Ñanderu, separated, and today lives in Panambi Lagoa Rica, municipality of Douradina, where he started a new family.

- Valdomiro Oswaldo, 64 years old



Born in a time of the dispossession of his people, son of João Aquino and Marcelina Costa da Silva, grandson of Paulito Aquino. He was raised by his grandparents, as was the custom of the time. Married to the Ñandesy prayer leader Roseli Concianza Jorge, with whom he built a family, with prayers and songs as their heritage.

● Jorge Gomes, 62 years old



He was born on January 5, 1959. He lives in the village of Pirakua, in the municipality of Bela Vista, where through prayers and much struggle they reclaimed their traditional territory. He is a Ñanderu prayer leader, political leader of his community, and actively participates in the struggles for the guarantee of the original and constitutional rights of his people. He was coordinator of the Aty Guasu and is currently an active advisor.

- Valério Vera Gonçalves, (in memoriam), 73 years old



Ñanderu prayer leader and advisor. He was born on February 19, 1948, in Jataivera Lima Campo, from where he was expelled along with his people, but through the struggle they reclaimed part of the territory, which was recognized and returned to the relatives. He provided assistance to the tekoha, such as Kokwe'i, in Xiru Karai. He was very active in his mission of praying for people, but, as every flower must be picked, he went to adorn the heavenly gardens on March 20, 2021. He was living in Panambi Lagoa Rica Village, in the municipality of Douradina.

- Eliel Benites, 42 years old



Professor and Director of the Indigenous Intercultural Faculty (FAIND/UFGD). He was born and lives in the Tey'ikue village, municipality of Caarapó. He holds a degree in Intercultural Teaching Degree for Indigenous Peoples, Teko Arandu, and a master's degree in Education from the University Dom Bosco Catholic University (UCDB), and a Ph.D. in Geography from UFGD. He is part of the Movement of Guarani and Kaiowá Teachers and is an active member of the Cultural Association of Indigenous Filmmakers (ASCURI).

- Marilda Duarte, 53 years old



Ñandesy prayer leader. Artisan. Specialist in traditional medicine and Guarani craftwork. She lives in the Bororó Indigenous Reserve of Dourados.

And finally, Fineida Aquino Concianza, 47 years old, daughter of Nelson Concianza and Rosalina Aquino, born in Panambizinho, municipality of Dourados. It was not possible to record an image of Fineida.

Drawing on the dialogues, reflections, and observations shared with these people who helped me build this research, I sought to understand how Kaiowá and Guarani agricultural theory is configured, taking into account the relationship with human beings, non-human beings, the surrounding world, and food production. The ethnographic record, from an indigenous perspective, makes it possible to place this material in dialogue with the formulations produced by indigenous researchers from

other peoples and other traditional communities, as well as by non-indigenous researchers.

I sought to investigate and ethnograph the food-production rituals among the Kaiowá and Guarani, with special attention to the spiritual technologies used in the making and management of Kaiowá and Guarani gardens (*roças*). I call Spiritual Technologies the negotiations carried out between human and non-human beings in the rituals and ceremonies performed for the planting, harvesting, and consumption of certain foods cultivated by the Kaiowá and Guarani. This is our Kaiowá and Guarani science.

In this sense, I deepen the reflection on Indigenous Science with the thinking of the Kaiowá anthropologist Celuniel Valiente, which reflects the shift in the academic paradigm of which this work is part. We, Indigenous Peoples, once regarded merely as interlocutors of research, have come to occupy the role of indigenous researchers and protagonists of our own epistemological systems, proposing a respectful and just dialogue between the sciences:

Indigenous science cannot be characterized as lesser than Western science, but rather thought of through the interaction or dialogue between these different forms of knowledge that exist in the world. It is also necessary to remove indigenous knowledge from the traditional conception, that is, to discard it from the sphere of antiquity in which it is perceived as old and outdated; through a deeper look at this knowledge, one perceives the epistemological value it holds (VALIENTE, 2018, p. 202).



Preface

We are faced with a precious text, a true challenge to our modern, technological, and productivist culture. This is a study by a Kaiowá-Guarani indigenous author, Anastácio Peralta, entitled: *“Spiritual Technologies: Prayer, Cultivated Fields, and Sustainability among the Kaiowá and Guarani”*.

To understand his vision we must adopt another paradigm, one very close to the contemporary paradigms of deep ecology, quantum physics, and modern biology. The whole text is a dialogical confrontation with the modern way of relating to nature and with the mechanized production of the goods that sustain our life and culture.

The author, a professor and researcher, speaks in the first person. Methodologically, he first immerses himself in the indigenous reality of several villages (tekoha), observing the rhythm of life and the work, especially the rituals and festivals. He then consults, in long conversations, the guardians of ancestral culture, the elder women and men, retrieving ancestral wisdom and memory. Third, he interviews specific indigenous men and women, always providing a brief biography of the interviewees, as well as of the elders. From this he systematizes the accumulated knowledge, always in dialogue with our dominant culture.

Peralta represents well the cosmology of most native peoples. He puts it aptly: “The worldview of indigenous peoples rejects the separation between the human and nature, which greatly distinguishes it from the Western worldview. For us indigenous people, we are not separate from nature, we are part of it, or, better still, we are nature itself. This philosophy leads us

to approach the world around us with care and respect, for if we harm nature we harm ourselves.”

He gives clear meaning to his writing: “In this dissertation, I, Anastácio Peralta, of the Kaiowá people, who since childhood have fought for survival, bring in my own history and in the history of my people the desire for us to be protagonists and sovereign, as we once were in the past, with regard to food, territorial, and spiritual sovereignty.”

For the Kaiowá-Guarani, everything is suffused with life; everything forms one great community of life that encompasses all human beings, the mountains, the waters, the plants, the animals, and especially the seeds. All life demands respect, veneration, and the cultivation of the sacred dimension. Different is the “karai reko,” the way of life of white people and moderns. For them, the earth and nature, with everything that exists within them, have a merely utilitarian function, a reality without purpose in itself, available for human exploitation.

The central axes of the theoretical framework revolve around the themes of territory (the so-called reserves, always under threat), the seeds, white corn, and the “tekoha” (the village). But the driving axis of it all consists in spiritual technology. It is made up of sacred rituals, long prayers, and interaction with visible and invisible life (energies-spirits).

Peralta shows — and herein lies the singularity of his research — that we do not need the machines of the modern paradigm to produce everything we need. Moreover, the very use of such apparatuses, however sophisticated, offends Mother Earth.

There is another way of producing and also of healing that uses the spiritual energies present in all beings — these are the spiritual technologies. He says: “I call Spiritual Technologies the

negotiations carried out between human and non-human beings in the rituals and ceremonies performed for the planting, harvesting, and consumption of certain foods cultivated by the Kaiowá and Guarani. This is our Kaiowá and Guarani science.”

The clearest example of this spiritual technology is revealed in the seeds: “they possess a complex spiritual technology, capable of dying and reviving, bearing fruit and feeding the other living species of planet Earth.” The seed, with reverence, is placed in the lap of Mother Earth and is cared for at every one of its stages. It represents the perpetuity of life and of human nourishment.

Moreover, Peralta deepens the central question of spiritual sustainability, in the sense of creating all the conditions for the Kaiowá and Guarani life-system and existence to remain alive and healthy. Indigenous peoples have created the category equivalent to the Andean “bien vivir,” which they call “teko porã.”

This vital energy present in all things is evoked through prayer. Prayer, guided by the prayer leaders (ñanderu and ñandesy), is fundamental because through it they enter into communion with the essence of life that manifests in all beings, but reaches its greatest concentration in the seeds. They state with conviction: “We, Kaiowá and Guarani, believe that as long as we remain steadfast in the pursuit of techniques arising from the spiritual world, we hold the hope of full life within us, indigenous peoples, and within all the other beings who inhabit this world.”

Peralta approaches the theme critically with regard to transculturality. He realizes that the relationship between Kaiowá-Guarani culture and our own is asymmetrical. However hard white people try to approach indigenous people in a

friendly way, it is always a look from above to below. There is an immense disproportion between the dominating force of modern culture, grounded in power-domination over nature, and indigenous culture, founded on the nature of which they feel themselves bearers. They are nature, and they love and care for it. And white people devastate it to the point of endangering all life. We white people seek, at most, an alternative development, whereas they seek an alternative to development. They present it through spiritual technologies.

Peralta realizes how modern culture penetrates especially the young. They belong to two worlds, the modern and at the same time, they take part in the life and ritual festivals. But he notes a spiritual weakening.

I want to stress the importance of the fact that the Kaiowá themselves are training their own researchers with their own outlook, better than those who come from outside with a different outlook. We have much to learn from them, for our civilization seems to have reached its own limits. The researcher and professor Peralta gives us a fine example of this innovative research.

Let this confession by Peralta serve as our conclusion: "It is precisely against this spiritual weakening that we fight, it is for this continuity of life that we resist. We, the Kaiowá and Guarani Kwery, are concerned not only with our human life, but we are also concerned with the natural balance, we are concerned with spiritual lives; the seeds give us examples of resistance when they react to every attack and thus, unrestrained and exuberant, make use of their spiritual techniques and teach us generosity."

If one day our civilization should collapse for having destroyed the foundations that sustain all life — and this is not impossible, since we have created the very principle of self-

destruction — it will be through the worldview and the values so well represented by Kaiowá-Guarani culture that the survivors will be able to refound a friendly and caring way of inhabiting our Common Home. Through this research, Anastácio Peralta hands us the undying seed of a future of hope and of the joy of living.

Leonardo Boff

The Kaiowá and Guarani Peoples: forest peoples, peoples of struggle!

The great Guarani People speak languages belonging to the Tupi-Guarani linguistic trunk and are organized into three peoples: Guarani Mbya, Guarani Ñandeva, and Guarani Kaiowá. This book focuses on the Guarani Kaiowá and Guarani Ñandeva peoples, the second-largest indigenous group in Brazil, who live in the state of Mato Grosso do Sul, where they call themselves Kaiowá and Guarani, or Guarani and Kaiowá. I am part of this Great People!

The strip of territory traditionally occupied by the Kaiowá and Guarani, in the southern cone of the state of Mato Grosso do Sul, was quite extensive and lay between the Apa River and the Serra de Maracaju. This territory came to occupy a considerable stretch from east to west of the Serra de Amambai, encompassing much of the Brazil-Paraguay border (Pereira, 2007).

Today these peoples find their territories greatly diminished, such that they now occupy small areas located in a strip of land on each side of the Brazil-Paraguay border region, where they are called Pãi Tavyterã (MELIÀ, 1976).

The occupation of territories by these peoples has always been linked to areas rich in natural resources considered suitable for maintaining the Kaiowá and Guarani way of being, that is, the teko. In this sense, they established their villages, or tekoha, in areas close to rivers and forests. Beyond this, the selected area had to be free of disease and of threats from malignant spirits (PEREIRA, 2016).

By origin and tradition, we Kaiowá and Guarani are forest farmers; we practice hunting and fishing and gather seeds, fruits, and other natural riches offered by Mother Earth in our territory.

However, our territory today finds itself extremely reduced and damaged owing to the ignorance of the karai (non-indigenous people), who see nature as a commodity and take from it everything possible, without thinking of the consequences.

Recent surveys estimate the Kaiowá and Guarani population at more than 50,000 individuals (PEREIRA, 2016). Our relatives are living in eight reserves and fourteen indigenous lands, totaling 22 indigenous areas. However, since the late 1990s, the number of areas occupied by the Kaiowá and Guarani has been gradually growing. This is because our people have been reorganizing and are thus claiming and demanding the demarcation of our traditional lands expropriated by agribusiness occupation. This movement is characterized as the reclaiming of the ancestral territory that was stolen, and it draws on the strength of the traditional masters, the Nãnderu and the Nandesy (BENITES, 2014).

Nowadays, most of the Kaiowá and Guarani live in indigenous reserves, which were created in the early twentieth century (between 1915 and 1928) by the Indian Protection Service (SPI) (CAVALCANTE, 2014; PEREIRA & MOTA, 2012). The function of these reserves was to shelter the indigenous people who were being expelled from their ancestral territories, which were plundered and impoverished by colonization projects that had captured the minds of the karai with the idea of development.

The ignorance and racism of white people are made explicit in the process of occupying agricultural areas in Mato Grosso do Sul. It is a policy stemming from an idea that disregards the rights of native peoples and treats us as though we were not people worthy of rights. This brutal way of conducting policy has brought disastrous consequences to the environment and to our culture, brutally impacting the native vegetation and

promoting great imbalances in the local ecosystems of the Kaiowá and Guarani, in addition to destabilizing our way of living, understanding the world, and walking our path.

Amid all this complexity in which my people live, I describe and analyze the knowledge, practices, and rituals mobilized by the Kaiowá and Guarani peoples, especially the spiritual technologies involved in the production of gardens (roças) and food. More specifically, I focused on understanding the knowledge mobilized for the rituals, ceremonies, and festivals practiced by the Kaiowá and Guarani, past and present, in the tekoha and reserves, for the planting and harvesting of food.

To that end, I present how Kaiowá and Guarani agricultural theory is configured, so as to understand the forms of care given to seeds and plantings, and the planting-tool technologies used in the past and in the present day. Beyond this, I seek to understand how the spiritual technologies used for Kaiowá and Guarani sustainability are organized.

Kaiowá Sustainability: indigenous science in defense of Mother Earth

We, Guarani and Kaiowá, have a specific worldview, defined as our particular way of seeing, thinking, ordering, and feeling the world. In this way of seeing and feeling the world, there is a strong relationship between the Kaiowá and Guarani worldview and culture, with visible and invisible beings, with spirituality, and with the celestial planes.

Thus, indigenous worldviews must be considered within the context of their cultural values and environmental knowledge. In this way, each indigenous people has its own worldview, which in turn relates to the specific context in which each people is

situated, such that territorial and ecological aspects influence their vision of the world.

The worldview of indigenous peoples rejects the separation between the human and nature, which greatly distinguishes it from the Western worldview. For us indigenous people, we are not separate from nature, we are part of it, or, better still, we are nature itself.

This philosophy leads us to approach the world around us with care and respect, for if we harm nature we harm ourselves.

For non-indigenous people, nature is at the service of human beings, which is why they exploit its riches endlessly. For us indigenous people, the human being is nature; we are interconnected within a single web of life, each caring for the other. Nature, for us, is a living being, one that must be admired, cared for, and loved. And just as we do not separate humans from nature, we do not separate nature from culture, as non-indigenous people do.

In this way, the Kaiowá and Guarani worldview, driven by a spiritual mindset of care and respect for Mother Earth, prevents the development of an economy based on the notion of exploitation and profit, as occurs in the capitalist system. In the Kaiowá and Guarani socioeconomic system, of a cooperative type, work is carried out through a feeling of solidarity rather than of competition.

The concept of sustainability is a concept from the non-indigenous Western world and is related to the term “sustainable development.” These concepts reflect the perspective of that which seeks to meet the needs of the current generation without compromising the life and needs of future generations. In this sense, the logic of these concepts aligns with the idea of

producing profits, being socially just, and environmentally sound (SACHS, 2002).

Thus, for the researcher Rosa Colman, another aspect that cannot be dissociated from local development and territory is the question of sustainability. “Addressing sustainability and local development presupposes living under a new ethic, guided by commitment and responsibility toward the promotion and defense of life in all its senses” (COLMAN, 2009).

One of the intellectuals of the quilombola people, Antônio Bispo dos Santos, known as Nêgo Bispo, offers a highly important reflection on aspects of sustainability. This quilombola and traditional master reflects on the obstacles between the thinking and the practice of sustainability as carried out at the hands of the colonizers:

In contemporary debates we can also perceive some efforts at transfluence, when we analyze the attempts to combine different principles and/or perspectives within some productive processes such as: sustainable development, organic production, agroecological, agroforestry, permaculture, ethnodevelopment, etc. It is an attempt to bring together thoughts, concepts, and values. However, when we move on to actually implementing these thoughts, concepts, and values, we once again encounter major confrontations (SANTOS, 2015, p. 51).

With regard to indigenous sustainability, the anthropologist Dominique Tilkin Gallois reflects:

“Sustainability” is considered a goal, an objective, not a public policy. If any sustainability policy exists, it can only be an indigenous policy. Formulating a public policy of “indigenous sustainability” would necessarily lead us into serious contradictions. In the indigenist field, public policies are currently aimed at meeting emergency demands, practicing a form of assistentialism that has already shown itself to be, and continues to be, the main cause of the rupture in the sustainability of the

indigenous way of life. For this reason, this text prefers to speak of sustainability as a goal, just as indigenous autonomy is also considered a goal. This text proposes that there should be a more detailed discussion of how, in projects supposedly aimed at indigenous sustainability, the entire system of production, distribution, and consumption is worked out, taking into account the importance and the value that indigenous groups attribute to the logic of exchange, of giving and receiving. Everything indicates that, in many cases, the “culture of projects” has encouraged the transformation of this logic into a much simpler equation: receiving support through projects with no precise goal other than the drafting of the next project (GALLOIS, 2005, p. 1).

Thus, it becomes necessary to develop internal and external policies to guarantee the sustainability of our people, with regard to our spirituality, our territories, our food, and the environment with all its diversity of fauna, flora, and beings. In this sense, I am not referring only to sustainability as it is conceived in the world of the *karaí*, where they think only of profit and of land as personal, commercial property, where wealth is extracted from Mother Earth without regard for her death and the consequent death of all living beings.

Also on the subject of Kaiowá and Guarani sustainability, the Kaiowá author and researcher Sônia Pavão, from the Limão Verde village, reflects:

That the search for balance in our Mother Earth needs to be thought of as a collective, community action to strengthen and restore the richness of nature. This means that, for us, the plants, the animals, the water, the earth, the air, the stones, the mountains — in other words, everything that makes up the planet has life and deserves to be cared for and protected. Unlike white people, who see everything as merchandise and think only about making money off the death of nature (PAVÃO, 2021, p. 121).

Building on this notion of territory and sustainability, for the Kaiowá and Guarani it is not possible to achieve sustainability merely by recovering small parcels of land, as the testimony of the Kaiowá researcher Eliel Benites demonstrates:

We are living through a moment of reconstruction: a new direction after the disaster of confinement; we perceive the urgency of the land question, our reserves are small and degraded. Policies are needed that know how to handle all the differences, even from village to village, without continuing with isolated actions. Policies of community reorganization through technical training of the community and based on the community's own vision. The community's unity has been broken down; the community itself lacks clarity about what it wants. Enabling communities to rethink their own lives. This organization has to be strong in order to engage with the surrounding community. Preparation aimed at strengthening indigenous knowledge. Not transplanting indigenous knowledge into the white system, but building the system of indigenous knowledge. Only in this way is sustainability built (URQUISA, 2006:2 *apud* BENITES, 2014).

Reflecting on the need to move beyond the Western concept of sustainability in order to truly glimpse and understand the notions on this theme that involve the cosmology of indigenous communities, the researcher Rosa Colman notes:

To approach the concept of sustainability from the standpoint of indigenous communities, it is essential to understand the concept of nature. And to do this it is necessary to disarm oneself of the orthodox, Western, and capitalist concept, which perceives nature in a hierarchical way, as domination, and in a separate, compartmentalized way. And to observe with sensitivity and realize that it is possible, as it is for indigenous peoples, to relate to nature in a different way, without “dominating,” without so much “transforming,” and more by understanding the different processes that occur there. Thus, sustainability for these populations depends more on the capacity for understanding,

respect, and integration than on the domination and transformation of nature (COLMAN, p. 92).

I came to understand that the term sustainability, for my people, means working collectively, admiring, caring for, and loving our Mother Earth, because we need worlds that are sustainable. Mother Earth asks for our help. But for us, Kaiowá and Guarani, it is not possible to have sustainability without having the land, without having our territory, which was stolen and destroyed by colonizing hands. We need the land because she is the one who gives us life, who nurses us. And it is the land that also gives us the strength to produce food, to produce life.

But it is not only the land that guarantees our Kaiowá and Guarani sustainability. We also have spiritual sustainability, in which prayers, songs, rituals, and celebrations are very important and must always be practiced. We have to pray, we have to sing in order to produce food, for the rain to come, to baptize the land, to plant the seed, and for the harvest. So sustainability is a whole, a system, that is part of our indigenous science, our Kaiowá and Guarani science.

So, according to our science, it is not only food that will guarantee our sustainability. For us, Kaiowá and Guarani, being sustainable is something broad and complex, in which it is necessary to build a healthy environment, starting from where we live, from where we dwell. The water has to be healthy, and so do the plants, from those that are food to those that are medicine and those that are firewood.

To produce all this sustainability, we need good-quality land, a healthy, living land, full of joy, able to shelter many beings and plants, but to achieve this harmony we also need a great deal of spiritual management, of care, of rain. And we indigenous people, Kaiowá and Guarani, also understand the importance

and value of spiritual sustainability, because spirituality is what gives us the strength to keep our prayers, our songs, and all our ritual firm — the ritual that makes the earth nourish itself, the seed germinate, the rain fall, and the plants grow.

The land, the soil, is the cradle of the seed; it is where the seed remains dormant, sleeping until the rainwater falls, descending from the sky to bless the seed. Then, the moment the water falls, the seed awakens and begins to take root and to sprout. In this view, sustainability is a set of forces, of movements, of events, which need to happen in a dynamic and synchronized way. Everything has to be interconnected, has to happen at the right time, in the right moon for planting, with the right amount of rain, on the right day. And the harvest, too, has to be carried out at the exact moment, the sacred moment, to celebrate and give thanks so that, next year, it will come back for us to plant and have food again.

A sustainable people must be strong in its faith, and this spirituality involves many aspects that govern the life of my people. For this reason, I approach Kaiowá and Guaraní sustainability through the following subthemes: spiritual sustainability, territorial sustainability, food sustainability, and environmental sustainability, since, according to our Kaiowá system, these concepts are part of a holistic vision, one that looks not only at the materialized aspect of the world and of society, but, in a deeply humanized way, observes the interior of beings and their inner health — that is, it is concerned with practicing living well.

Here it is important to note that the separation of the aspects of Kaiowá and Guaraní sustainability into subthemes was done for the sake of organizing the text, but it is important to stress that these four aspects are intimately related to one another and are interdependent and complementary.

Spiritual Sustainability



Figure 1. Meeting with the Nandesy of Panambizinho. Source: Xiru Karaí Archive.

After listening to elders, both men and women, I set myself to understanding what the karaí understand by sustainability in spiritual matters, and I was then surprised by some of the meanings and statements of non-indigenous thinkers who are also concerned with planetary life. Among my inquiries, what struck me most and gave me the greatest grounding was an interview in which the philosopher Leonardo Boff explains that the transition to a sustainable society includes reducing consumption, reusing and recycling materials, and changing the economic system. The philosopher stressed that all of this only gains consistency if it is supported by a spirituality, in the sense of understanding that everything is connected to the whole. Thus, it becomes clear that it is important to live this dimension not only in awareness, but as a lived experience. He adds that sustainability means guaranteeing that all beings have available

to them the conditions to live, reproduce, and remain alive in their ecosystems (BOFF, 2014).

In this way, sustainability is a systemic concept whose principal aspect, for us Kaiowá and Guarani, is spiritual maintenance and strengthening. This is the thinking of my people and of so many other peoples who live in harmony with life in all its magnitude.

And on this journey of mine, perceiving the cultural and consequently spiritual weakening of my people, while at the same time observing the perseverance of my brothers and sisters in the struggle for the tekoha, I felt a restlessness in my being, searching for what would be necessary for us to become self-sufficient once again. Thus, I sought to understand what sustainability is for the Kaiowá Guarani, through the elders, the Ñanderu and Ñandesy; and with this knowledge I felt encouraged to contribute to the elders who struggle through prayer, who seek in Ñanderu Guasu words of wisdom, of consolation, of hope, of accomplishment.

Reflecting on the last few decades, I sense the estrangement and the flood of other religions entering our territories, causing uncertainties and doubts among the younger generations; that is why I wanted to understand the reason for the spiritual weakening of my people, which is one of the tragic consequences of the loss of our territory.

On this point, I turned to historical reflection, going back to colonial Brazil, and I was able to see that, in every era, there was present in the minds of the colonizers the idea that we were a people without faith. Yet the faith of the peoples of the Americas was never monotheistic, as it was among the other peoples of the West. So I reflected that in our culture there is no single God; rather, there are many spirits, the owners of each created being.

On these differences between the conception of colonizing Western spirituality and that of the Original Peoples, the quilombola intellectual and master Nêgo Bispo prompts us to reflect on religiosity as a preponderant factor in the process of colonization, noting:

Believing that religion is a privileged dimension for understanding the diverse ways of living, feeling, and thinking about life among different peoples and societies, it is important to understand the differences and the dialogue between the monotheistic worldview of the colonizers and the polytheistic worldview of the counter-colonizers, reflecting on their effects and consequences in the processes of colonization and counter-colonization (SANTOS, 2015, p. 12).

In this way, our spiritual sustainability is upheld by the Ñanderu and Ñandesy, who keep the songs, prayers, and basic teachings for everyday life, as set out by the Kaiowá researcher Eliel Benites during this research: “living the *ava reko* means respecting the rules of one's people, such as living out the rituals with respect, with the teachings, performing the prayers, always living with a smile” (Eliel Benites, Tey'ikue).

On these same foundations that sustain the Kaiowá Guarani way of being, in the pursuit of living well, Nanderu Valério reflects:

We have to live smiling and happy. For this there is the prayer that every day I have to do in order to live. To have the *ava reko* we need the *teko porã*, which is based on harmony among families, on having food of our own, a specific care that is ours. But today our families are disorganized, family leaders are weakened. I feel that they are all *guaxos* because they are not heard, and seek to resolve their problems by seeking out the so-called political leadership (captain), who also does not resolve them. Nowadays, I see that parents and grandparents have lost the power of speech, and so we are living the *ava karaí*, without space, without fauna and flora. This way it is impossible to teach

the traditional way of being, and an example of this is that people no longer grow roça crops, because there is a basic food basket available, and so there is no longer a need to plant. In this way the prayer leaders, the elders, lose their values and respect. This has happened since the arrival of the non-indigenous way of being. The churches do not like indigenous people to go hunting, fishing. If they see indigenous people practicing these activities, they expel them right away.... In this sense, if the *ava reko* is *vai*, *pochi*, the *tekoha* is bad, and because of this, we need to seek ways to revive the communities so they carry out their rituals, such as *kunumy pepy* (the passage from the child cycle to adulthood, where boys learn songs, prayers, and how to behave like true *Kaiowá*) and, thus, rekindle the flame of spirituality and of *Kaiowá* culture (Valério Vera Gonçalves, Panambi Lagoa Rica).

Building on the reflection of Ñanderu Valério and of our brother, the quilombola community leader Nêgo Bispo, especially in his work *Colonização, Quilombos: modos e significações* (SANTOS, 2015), it is possible to draw a parallel, addressing and reflecting on how the State and the Church have committed, and still commit to this day, the crime of erasing, silencing, and killing spirituality against our ancient cultures: these institutions have worked, since colonialism, to put an end to our spiritual sustainability.

However, we indigenous peoples know how to develop a truly peaceful connection with nature, and for that we know that we must first learn to develop a respectful and non-violent relationship with ourselves. This transformation requires important inner work. When this work is combined with greater awareness and understanding of the subtle changes we wish to bring about in ourselves, we begin to appreciate our true spiritual personality and to live according to that knowledge. It is at this moment that we find our spiritual sustainability.

We know that the seed of spiritual sustainability lies in thought and action. If it lies in thought and action, then how do

we use this energy so that we may always live in aragwyje, that is, in fullness with the spiritual and material beings? Along these lines, the great companion, educator, and researcher Veronice Lovato Rossato, in her master's thesis, cites Paulito Aquino, a respected Kaiowá cacique who warns: "Only with prayer can we calm violence, only with song can we cool people's tempers" (ROSSATO, 2002, p. 44).

The author confirms Kaiowá thought when she says that the word (*ně'ě ayvu*) is the center and origin of everything; it is the germ of life, the "divine substance" of Ñanderu (Our Father), from which people proceed. When a child begins to speak, it means that the spirit has manifested within them, that is, life in its fullness, our essence, our true being. The word is voice, speech, language, tongue, soul, name, life, origin, personality (ROSSATO, 2002, p. 31). Therefore, to strip us of the right to speech is to deny our *teko*, our existence, and thus to undermine our spiritual sustainability.

When I lived with Paulito, Balbina, and their family, I learned that Ñanderu created all languages as different from one another. I was also taught that language is our very soul, and without it we are nothing; without it we are unrecognizable before God. That is why, when we stop speaking our language, we lose our soul, our spirituality, and we can no longer maintain dialogue with Ñanderu. We are left lost in the cosmos, not knowing where or when to act. For us, the Kaiowá and Guaraní peoples, there is no *ně'ě* without *teko*, no *teko* without *ně'ě*, and no *tekoha* without *ava*. That is, there is no life without soul-word and vice versa, just as there is no territory without its original inhabitants and their *jara* (divine owners).

In this way, it is essential that each people ensure the use of their language wherever they may be, so that we may maintain our spirituality, regardless of our acquiring other languages to

dialogue with other human beings. To speak with Ñanderu, one must live the rituals and speak our mother tongue, for He comprehends and understands all the languages He created. Keeping our language strong also strengthens spiritual sustainability.

But colonization nearly destroyed our system when, through the Pombaline law, it stripped us of the right to communicate in our own language. When the government created the SPI (Indian Protection Service), it placed so-called captains at the head of the peoples, who, entangled with the church—that is, "converted" to evangelicalism or Christianity—demonized and even physically assaulted the prayer leaders, carrying forward the project to destroy the strong language and spirituality of the Kaiowá Guarani.

On the path of resistance to this process of violation, the sensibility of spirituality through traditional prayers gives rise to a collective connection, of intuition and affectivity, manifesting the true and manifold Kaiowá and Guarani way of being, as the indigenous researcher Elemir Martins reflects (2020). In his own words: "The words of the prayers are sacred, inspired by the Guarani words of the mediator between the earthly world and the supernatural world" (MARTINS, 2020, p. 52).

Ñembo'e (prayers) and porahei (songs) guide existence, orient traditional knowledge and territorial self-management, and also lead to sustainability, besides constituting the seed that germinates resistance for life, for territory, and for autonomy. It is in this sense that I stress the importance of spirituality in the territorial struggle as a fundamental axis in the construction of sustainable life in the Kaiowá and Guarani view. In the words of Kaiowá and Guarani researcher Elemir Martins:

The Ñanderu gained prestige in the struggle against oppression, for being guardians of knowledge, which is why they are

regarded by many indigenous people as the principal religious leaders. (...) The generation of prayer leaders who are in the struggle today went through a period of preparation, during which they actively took part in every religious activity of the old indigenous spiritual leaders, for these knew what was to come. In this sense, they invested in the preparation of future prayer leaders. The Kaiowá and Guaraní cosmology, according to the prayer leaders, is strengthened by the power of prayer and indigenous wisdom (MARTINS, 2020, p. 87).

From this perspective, nurturing spiritual sustainability is the most fundamental and important step so that the entire sustainable system of Kaiowá and Guaraní life and existence can remain alive and healthy. It is from spiritual sustainability that the other sustainabilities derive. It is the fundamental axis that allows us to live in a harmonious and healthy world. And even in the face of so many violent attacks, the Kaiowá and Guaraní peoples remain steadfast in the struggle to maintain all indigenous spirituality, which is fundamental to enabling the existence of our people.

Territorial Sustainability



Figure 2: Meeting with the Ñandesý and the Ñanderu in Panambizinho.
Source: Xiru Karaí Archive.

According to our system, the famous phrase of the late Bartomeu Melià (in his memory), "without tekoha there is no teko," defines our system well: the existence of the territory is essential for there to be a healthy environment and sustainable food; but all of this is only viable if it is sustained by the technology of spirituality.

According to Kaiowá researcher Eliel Benites, the category of traditional territory and the origin of the Kaiowá and Guaraní are present in the narratives of prayer leaders (Ñanderu and Ñandesy) and make possible a better understanding of the great wisdoms of these peoples "in relation to their territoriality or the place where they live, and also the cultural and sacred elements that contribute to defining the importance of the cosmological meanings of the land, according to traditional culture" (BENITES, 2014, p. 35).

Kaiowá historian Gileandro Barbosa Pedro stresses the need to maintain the connection with the territory and its guardians, so that occupation strategies "are guided by the way of life arising from the ava reko, which, in turn, should be lived in harmony with the well-being of the teko (traditional way of living)" (PEDRO, 2020, p. 31). To build the tekoha, the place had to be suitable and undergo the process of prayer to drive away evil spirits, thus confirming the interconnection between spirituality and territoriality for our people.

In the past, we Kaiowá and Guaraní had an environment that was sustainable by nature. It was a complete body lacking nothing; we ourselves and nature served one another mutually, in harmony. But the system of the karaí, that is, colonialism and capitalism, sold the idea that quality of life and social ascent necessarily pass through consumption, as Boff points out (2009).

Thus, in order for some to consume to the fullest, others must consume insufficiently. "It is inhuman and irrational that 327 families possess nearly half of all the wealth on Earth, and that three individuals have more income than 48 countries where 600 million people live. This represents an offense against human rights," the philosopher stresses (BOFF, 2009, p. 1).

The fact that he is a convinced humanist does not, however, prevent Boff from being critical of the mechanistic view of nature that became consolidated in the twentieth century. The philosopher believes that we must overcome anthropocentrism and the illusion that the human being is the center of everything. According to Boff, the human being is a link in the chain of life, for life is one and unitary. In this way, all living beings are made up of the same 20 amino acids and the same four phosphate bases. Therefore, we are all brothers and sisters (BOFF, 2009, p. 1).

On the developmentalist policy of recolonization by the State, which in Kaiowá and Guarani territory unconditionally supports agribusiness and completely destroys any attempt at sustainability, the great intellectual Ailton, of the Krenak people, offers an important reflection:

So in this position as sponsors of our progress, these gentlemen believe they have the right to commit every kind of barbarity, including carrying out a genocide against the Kaiowá-Guarani people in Mato Grosso do Sul, justifying it by saying that this year they exported 200 million tons of grain, most of which is soy. It is monoculture, it uses poison, it poisons the water sources, the bodies of water, it poisons people directly, you don't even need to wait to drink the water afterward, you can just drink the poison straight away. And just because these people bring a few billion into the Brazilian economy, they believe they have the right to poison us. That's recolonization. To recolonize is exactly that. To recolonize is to bring in a demand that isn't ours, to export our water and our soil, to create poverty in these places, not to give

these people the opportunity to establish themselves with dignity. And the most that is left for the neighbors of these enterprises is to be cheap labor, with the aggravating factor that the technologies applied today in this field, in this large-scale production, increasingly do without human labor and specialize in the use of machines, of other expensive technologies that we don't manufacture, we buy. So we keep creating this circle of dependency, where indigenous peoples and the territories where indigenous peoples still manage to subsist are becoming almost the last strongholds where fauna and some biodiversity can survive (KRENAK, 2015, p. 333-334).

In Kaiowá and Guarani territories, the forest and landscape diversity were almost completely destroyed by the *karaí reko* and by the colonialist political project, with the consolidation of the State and the creation of Indigenous Reserves for the expansion of the monopolization of land, of agriculture and livestock farming, and of agribusiness, especially from 1970 onward. This has shaped a broad process of ecosystem degradation, poisoning, fragmentation, insecurity, and territorial precarity for our people.

In this narrative, the problems, conflicts, and violence faced by the Kaiowá and Guarani are closely related to the loss of a significant part of the *tekoha*, to the impositions of the enclosures represented by the Indigenous Reserves, to the profound territorial precarity and ecological degradation, and, consequently, to the need to meet most needs and carry out most work outside the village, since biodiversity in the traditional territory has been substantially reduced (BENITES, 2020).

For this reason it is necessary to engage in dialogue and to better understand the workings of the internal and external policies that involve us, and thus to have clear objectives, since we indigenous people can only be sustainable once we have our territory back, in communion with spirituality. In this way it will

be possible to reconquer our territory and thereby help Mother Earth in her natural resilience.

I believe that if we understand that a leader can bring people together and change the human mind to the point of putting their lives at the service of the struggle, as in the case of Sepé Tiaraju,⁶ a surprising reaction in the reconquest of our territories would be possible. The problem is that today we are unable to react to the system in which we are embedded, because we are guaxos, as Nãnderu Valério said in his words already quoted here.

In the past, our leaders had voice and standing within and outside the community, but today, after the entry of the teko karaí (the non-indigenous way of being) into our midst, we disregard our elders, we seek instead to listen to what the karaí say, and thus we lose our customs, traditions, and spirituality, letting ourselves be contaminated by the capitalist system, leaving forgotten our teko joja (harmonious way of walking).

In light of these reflections, it becomes clear that for there to be territorial sustainability, there must first be spiritual sustainability. If our spirits are healthy and joyful, if we are able to ensure our prayers, songs, rites, and celebrations, we will be able to maintain the Kaiowá and Guaraní system of sustainability.

6 Great Brazilian indigenous warrior, declared by law a "Guaraní-Missionary hero of Rio Grande do Sul."

Food Sustainability



Figure 3: Hunt. Personal archive.

In indigenous wisdom, according to the elders, such as the late elder of Aldeia Panambizinho, Paulito Aquino, food defines people, such that you are what you eat. So, if you eat cassava that has been well planted and well blessed, it will also give you health, just as if you eat good corn, it will give health and joy to the body. This is because, for us indigenous people, everything is life, unlike the way the white man sees life. Production also comes from people, from the human, so production is human, corn is human, cassava is human, because it was produced by people, and so they also converse, speak to one another, and rejoice together (PERALTA, 2017).

The stories told by Dona Odalícia, of the tekoha Panambizinho, about her childhood and adolescence here in the Dourados region, tell a little about the relationship between the diversity of life and good food in the past:

We were sustainable, we had great abundance, food was never lacking no! There really was a lot of food, we were free and everyone had plenty of good food. There was no poison in the

fields, we ate a lot of hu'i, lots of roasted sweet potato, cassava, fish, capybara, agouti. We had everything! I remember when we all used to go to the fields, grown-ups and children alike, there we played and worked at the same time. We harvested a lot of food, rice, kumanda, acara, sweet potato, avati, and we would make a fire, roast avati, and eat a lot right there. In those days there was no mitã piru (malnourished child). Now here in Panambizinho has very few piru children, because we still have plenty of our own food and prayer too, but now there are already younger mothers, who don't want to make xixá for the children, nor make hu'i. They only eat what comes in the basic food basket, and that is bad food, it leaves us weak and sick. I miss when we used to go to the yguasú, we would pack provisions to eat along the road, we would go gathering guavirá, mbokaja, mixirica fruits. There was plenty of pakowá, we would gather a lot of fish, a whole lot! We would stay there five, six days. Afterward we would return to the tekoha. There wasn't even a fence, it was all open, but, then the karaí arrived and started closing everything off. We could no longer even go in to fish, or gather fruit, everything was torn away, the forest, our fields, everything was finished... (tears). My father used to say that now was a hard time and that we had to pray. We were confined to 60 ha, after much struggle we got back part of our tekoha, but already there is no more forest, nor animals. Everything is finished! I think the work you all are doing will help my great-grandchildren and the family have more good food. Agwyjevete. (Odalícia Concianza - in memory - of Panambizinho).

That is how my people were: rich in food and medicine. We did not depend on the market, on pharmacies, we had everything, as shown by the testimony of this woman who kept the good moments of our people in her memory. In this way, I think that today's generations suffer the consequences of this so-called economic development, for it is a generation that grew up without space to live its teko porã (good living). It is a generation that grew up being *un-wrapped* [des-envolvidos] from its food customs — that is, stripped of its way of being, living,

and eating. They learned to value industrialized foods, which has caused hunger, malnutrition, and other health problems.

Fostering the possibility of carrying out the prayers for preparing the soil, for planting and harvesting in the communities involved would be a way of leading the generations to once again acquire the habit of cultivation and the sustainable management of the tekoha. To carry out this training in awareness and in the strengthening of the individuals involved, and thus to produce healthy food free of poisons.

Food sustainability, known as sustainable food production, or as conservation agriculture, is one of the main objectives to be achieved in agriculture. Conservation agriculture seeks to learn from nature, where everything in the system is kept in balance and everything works in harmony. However, production systems that work with the conservation of ecosystems have been one of the greatest challenges for communities in recent decades.

From this perspective, several studies have shown that food sustainability is a viable goal, and that through the effort and dedication of the agricultural community it is possible to reach this objective. Our indigenous people, with our way of producing food developed ancestrally, in a harmonious and balanced manner, can point the way toward a new relationship with agriculture and food sovereignty.

Environmental Sustainability



Figure 4: Xiru Karaí, at Tekoha Panambizinho. Source: Xiru Karaí Archive.

Environmental sustainability is the key piece that closes the cycle of the discussions made so far, since the environment is the place that shelters, feeds, and helps give life to us humans and the other beings that make up the scene of Mother Earth. The environment is capable of suffering drastic aggressions and still benefiting us. However, its resilience does not operate on human time, and in recent times we have seen and heard, among all the native peoples and scientists, that the world is in collapse.

We see leaders across the whole world giving environmental speeches, setting goals to be reached, and trying to soften climate effects, but little is seen in practice to improve the planet's quality of life. And the people who are most affected by the environmental destruction caused by the non-indigenous way of living are precisely the peoples who live in the greatest connection with life in their territories. This is what is called environmental racism.

Western society has wrapped people up in a way of thinking and acting that produced a "consumer society," in which all the

wealth of the planet can be extracted to benefit a small group of the human population. They deforest, they pollute the rivers, they destroy mountains, they dig up the soil. All of this in the name of so-called progress. And in the midst of all this, what is left to us is a wounded environment, saddened, shaken by the greed of *karaí reko* (the white way of living). White people call this development [desenvolvimento], and in a way they are right, because in our view, this so-called development means removing the involvement [envolvimento] from relationships, since the prefix "des-" means separation, negation.

In a healthy environment we can live without so many economic expenses, we have our food and medicines available, with equity, respect, and care among all living beings. This way of thinking may seem like utopia to Western, capitalist society, but it was in exactly this way that our ancestors lived for millennia, in harmony and communion.

In this way, we indigenous peoples have applied, since our existence began, the ideas of sustainability, which take into account the harmony between ecosystems and societies; in such a way that we do not exhaust the riches of nature, we treat the environment with respect, we seek a balance between what we take and what we offer in return, and we consider that our planet is one, and that every action affects the whole, for life is interaction and everything is interrelated.

As the Kaiowá researcher Isaque João points out, in the traditional Kaiowá and Guaraní system of environmental management, the gathering of roots and fruits was always guided by the Ñanderu and Ñandesy so as not to provoke the displeasure of the *jara* (owners), and the strength of the *hexakáry's* (seer's) prayer was what protected the collective, attracted game animals, and maintained the fertility of the *kokuê* (cultivated field), making it possible to find the best place to live

amid all the biodiversity (JOÃO, 2011). These relations establish a harmonic dynamic among ecology, territory, and ancestral spirituality.

From this point of view, the reflections of the great shaman Davi Kopenawa alert us to the power of this interaction of life, in which we bear great responsibility for the care of all existing life:

The forest is alive. It will only die if white people insist on destroying it. If they succeed, the rivers will disappear beneath the earth, the ground will come undone, the trees will wither, and the stones will crack from the heat. The parched earth will be left empty and silent. The *xapiri* spirits, who come down from the mountain to play in the forest in their mirrors, will flee far away. Their fathers, the shamans, will no longer be able to call them and make them dance to protect us. They will not be able to drive away the smoke of epidemic that devours us. They will no longer manage to contain the evils, which will turn the forest into chaos. Then we will die, one after another, white people and us alike. All the shamans will end up dying. When there is no longer a single one of them alive to hold up the sky, it will fall (KOPENAWA and ALBERT, 2009, p. 6).

For us, Guarani and Kaiowá, caring for and managing the environment we live in is a social and spiritual duty, and our traditional agriculture allows the land to feed itself over a long period, so that it may recover its vigor, germinating again through the presence and agency of the *jára*. According to the Kaiowá anthropologist Celuniel Valiente, in this process, care is needed in managing the environment, taking great care not to affect the space of the other human; understanding that humans are many, not only those considered as such by the *karaí*'s view (VALIENTE, 2019).

Looking at the environment from a spiritual approach, as we indigenous peoples do, one notices that the source of change lies in inner strength. A spiritually conscious people will accept its

responsibility in this chain of events and will take a stand to protect life and keep the sky from falling. For us indigenous peoples, discussing internally and with the surrounding society the importance of Mother Earth's resilience, and our role in preserving and caring for the environment, will turn this failing world into a new world: fully alive and healthy.

To close this chapter, I have brought the words of Dona Marilda Duarte, Ñandesy of the Dourados village, who honored me with a visit to the Xiru Karaí, Panambizinho, on September 13, 2019, bringing a holistic and critical Kaiowá and Guarani view on Mother Earth and on the need for us to work on our Kaiowá and Guarani sustainability. I will present the text first in the Guarani language and then I will interpret her narrative.

Mba'éixapa enterovéva amombe'úta moõpa paiko. Xe réra Marilda Duarte, aiko aldeia Douradospe, Bororópe, amorá. Entonces xe tupã réra Kunhã Poty Rendy amoite ivanga arapoite xe réra ikunhã Oká Poty Rendy.

Entonces yvy rehegwa, yvy pyte rehegwa yvy pytã nhõarupi yvy oĩ ja, do outro ladia moyvy só que peteĩ, peteĩ maerãpe pa nhã'ẽ pe ikatu tavyterã guarani opaixagwa natureza, nhande tekohápe, entonces pe yvy maranã'ỹ rehegwa nhanderu Ty'apy Guasu, ha'e ojapo jave pe ko nhande planetarã ha'e mba'yre entonces ha'e ou ko yvýre opyta ha'e ou ko uvýre opyta entonces upéa oikotamo ko yvy ha'e ndoikatúi oiko ko yvýre ha'e ndaikatúi nhanderu. Entonces he'i, nhandesýpe Xiru Pa'i Kwara sýpe ha'i poty mirĩ sýpe, pe ha'i sy mirĩ sýpe he'i grávida xugwy ha ndaikatumo'ãi oraha hendie ojapo hagwa rógape.

Upépe ndaikatumo'ãi, nhaikatumo'ãi, oiko onhondive, marãmo ha'e ohóta japo róga yvága rapýpe ko'ãga oĩ hagwa ha'e upémarõ pe yvy ha'e oheja nhadévepe ndaikatu jaiko hagwa, nhandekwera, Paĩ Tavyterã kwéra je entero mi víxo kwéra oiko

hagwa yvy pepe. Só que ha'e omoĩ heta mba'e nhandéve rekorã ojeha nhande principalmente Xiru Pa'i Kwara ko yvy reko katu marañ'ỹ hagwa nhande, primera cosa ja'éta hína nhamongueta itỹmbire, itỹmbire ha'e ojeha nhandéve mbo'itypa heja mba'eixapa nde ka'arurã hagwa, oiko, entonces upéa mba'égywy ko yvýgwy oiko, ko yvýgwy oiko onasce ojatý, ojatý ikatu hagwaixa, onasce.

Entonces ha'ekwéra omombe'uha la dia, mba'eixapa ha'ekwéra ko yvy ojapoarã nhande hagwaete, etezia peve ha'e reko katu marañ'ỹ hagwa oje oiko hagwa kunhã ndéve ko yvy cada ano ha'ekwéra ohero ko yvy mba'eixapa cada ano ohero ko yvy cada ano ovela ombo'a vevó pe yvy katu haixagwa jajaty javehyupy nhande rembi'urã ovy'a hagwaixa pe itỹmbyre, ha'e cada ano ohero pe yvy. Ohasáva pe yvy ha'e porã serõ upeagwy.

Entonces upéa pe yvy nhonhemorõi oĩ mo'õpa ha'e hovasa hagwérõ pe três dias apeve yvy ha onhemo'e ramo mba onhemo'era mo yvy oĩ harapeso que ka'agwy mbyterope oĩ hesaya apeka cada ka'agwy pauraipy umi nhupa ureĩpe oĩ vae opa ko'ãga yvy y secopa ndorekói he'i mbayre nẽ'ẽ sadia veima pe yvy porque ka'agwy, ka'agwýre la opyrũ, cada pyhare tem ohosãmaikatu hagwaixa ha'e oguereko comunidade yvýpe nhande hagwa peivy porã hagwape ejaty akwe otera ka'agwy opaixagwa mi onace mi maerã. Ha ndaipóri ka'agwy jaety paete ojere kokwe guasu, maramõ opyta peagwy yvy ha'e oĩ rendépe ndahekokatúi marañ'ỹ ndorekói ndovy'ái ha'e.

Entonces renhonotýrejajátiramõ se me tỹgwe ha'e ja no po'ĩ porã véima entonces upéi pe oĩma ha'ekwéra heta ojapo yvy rehe oĩma adubo je ha opamba'e ojapo xupe porque depois quando nascer véima naturalmente. Nhande causa o seco, resseca jepeka ka'agwyetypa marãmo o sinai ndoyveima ha upéixa ko'ãga ne umi tekoharepe ... ndakatúi nhande itermina iterei ka'agwy katui jetepe ka'agwy jajety véima yvyra kwéra ikatu hagwã ogweru jey

upéa ka'agwýre, porã ka'agwyre, oĩ mbejo, oĩ nhũ, opaixagwa pohãiterei, pohã, pire, yvyra mata, peteĩ pire ha'e ombongwera hagwe ereru arã ndahaira momboaty ypohúra eterei, pera upea ... ogweru porã umi yvy nembo'egwere porã oĩhápe mba'asy nhande ... ikatu nhande rasy'i ipohĩma mba nde ramo mbotyra nhande tekoha como pohã ka'agwy pegwa seco pegwa, brexo pegwa, nde rerimboty ramo ikatu hagwáicha imbogwera e tekoha yva verde porque pohã pyre ha'e re'u rekai'u urembote'y ore, oĩ nde rasyete ramo, oĩ kwera, oĩ ikatu nhande rasy alguém machuca alguna cosa oĩ nhande kwéra jakwera voíre, voíre ogweraha oĩ zias kwera porãi hagwa ha upéi jave nderekói porãi tereré, rekai'u, rekai'u, rekai'u urei, como ainda reimba iporã pyre pohãrungwe oíre hagwã ha nderekwaaiva árupi ndaikwavéima pohã rogwe como pohã pyre ramo.

Pe nūpegwa pohã oĩ, oĩ héra avápe mamangá upe mbohaxa gwýpe yvyra mbohaxa gwýpe, yvyra upéa ha'e iporã rekai'u hagwã xupe, iporã kunhã ikyravape avei; py'a he'i ko hasy aje ora iporã ai iporã kai hagwã se ha iko rejapo pe mbohaxa xugwy pulando pytã ivai je ai ha upea iporã yve ha'e câncer, câncer de utero he'e mba'yre aje mamangá he'e xupe mba'eixa pomba'yre renhõi po ha'e ha mbejo pegwa katui ha'e heta eterei oĩ ohaisande ndaikwaaí oheja mbejo kunhã pyrũ mba'eve ... mbejope katu oĩ porã ysã opaixagwa pohã kunhã como jajajereko aikwa ramo pegwa heta ha'e porque oĩ mamó jei tei jei ko haropy opaixagwa pira é nhande ikatu já utiliza nhanhã pira, pira rampinha, pira juruaija, pira pochi, tarairã opaixagwa pira umia oje'u só que upe já'ua eikwe ã nde repo nderehe ainte ndere upei kunhã taí, como mitã guasu, ha omendadarã ha ojegwatase oje cria ha'e aje.

Entonses upéa rehe okokumatará tembi'ukwe he'i ymagware. Mba'eixapa ha'e popota esse ou remondiá upea, entoses kunhã kyra já memby ja'e membypa rire entonses upéa

pegwa mbejo rupi ha'e porã oĩ, oĩ rea upea remõi roesape oho he'u hagwãixa mboje, mbojeĩma ha'u hagwã oĩ brexope, ysyrype péixa osyry jave oĩ upea rehe otyky oho'a upea kaatu oĩma yvy are ndeve rehema oĩma upea katui py'a rupu porã e a pressão oĩma pohã indaikatui sofre a pressão enterovea jareko pressão aje. Entonses upea pegwa ha'e oĩ ave tarova rehe oho opovy'aruarem he oho, arẽ upea epy'a epy'a pohã pressão pohã, hate ysyry opyky vae opeivarẽ y arenyve he oho itárovare osyry upea ikatu hũ porã coração asipe, nde coração mancha pende coraçãope.

Entonses onhëgogwera upea tuixa mba'e coração tuixa, primeiro lugar hina, nde ha ela é voluntário, oĩ ndeve coração upea pohã ohopeĩre istriri avei oho itárovare tei oho ahina upe porã na missão, heta eterei oĩ pohã brexo pengwarã ja'úta nhande kwera, nhande kwera, porque nhandekwera ta ikatu tayterã, jareko gwa'e ke pressão nde re'u, jajereko nhacontrolado ja'u jajereko he'i mba'yre aje ai ja jarekopama hagwã oi, só que upéa arive oĩ opy'a oĩ mbarete rehe ope opeririá te ... aje upe'au pohã controlado pegwa é na mesma hora de johesa'y rehegwe pererokoi. Entonses mba'apo ne kane'õ ka'aru ramo nhamõi ikatu maraíke nde participa ne nhenhamõi nde py'a ko piriri piriri, entonses opea pegwa porã oĩ isã oĩ brexo umia ha'e brexo pegwa ha ose'i.

Ai ka'agwy jyvaete are nhamoíta hína porã mba'yrehe ýpe anemia ha'i anemia ha'i kunhã nderugwe nderehe pa'y nde mba'asy mē'ẽ aje nde ka'agwyre nde oho e upea iporã yvotyřã naimoãi veima ha jaremoĩma, eremoĩma yvyra pytã pire, ha remoĩma irunde pire, repy'a retoraí irunde'i pire pono que ne mbarete ha nde vare'a hagwã. Ape hendy'e pe kankoroza aje kankoroza, cachorro ha remõi poheia.

Huvixa moyremoirã, ophã guasu, huivixa moyremõi ko'anga omombe'uta xirixaha ko, ko pohã teĩ porãiterei peãga

ohendu rogwe pe ary pe kagware guasu rugwaigwe rehapy ipo'y ipo'y umi oĩ aje. Entonses rejara upearã hapy ha nde renhõi pupu arã pe ela huvixa anemia porã, hapyka ora poré moía randivepe, apohã guasu hina pea peteĩ pohã ija'e nhnade xupe peteĩ grupo, peteĩ pohã itirapáva nhânẽ'ẽ etepe aje itirapáva pea peteĩ pea seco ka'agwy rehegwa meme hina upea pió servi asy anemia pepe o servi pohã iterei.

Ome'ẽ primeira cosa nhande ogwereko he'i ko ha'ekwera aje xe ko omombe'uta pe'eme heí ha'ekwera aiko aje, aje nhamõi, nhande reko jara ivaikwe nhandeve. Entonses há'e upeixa aje yvy peypota jeiramo heí oime hapeterei pe mombo'e mba'ekwe hopi hagwã mba'era ihy upi umia jevyaramo pe'eme, entoses, nhande jajaty ha ka'agwyre jei nhambopoky.

Mba'eixa nacomẽça nhambohary hagwã, entonses ko'ape oĩ Arroyo aje, com Arroyo kota koi ndoikoi ka'agwy apenas amoite mixĩ oĩ ka'agwy, entonses ko ikontare direito já jaty hagwã mba'ere 500 metros nederredor japoã rã ka'agwy jaty, jaty paite irunde'i, yvyra pytã, jatobá, oĩ agwyer (?) até umi yva já'u aje ha'u ikatu hangwãixa e sombra ha ousã ha upeare ikatu hangwãixa ha upeixala yvy jara. Nhande kwera ko ja'iu yhyjaregwarei nhande ja'iu ipemina própria na ja'iu.

Outro ha'e ko y peteĩ outro mundo ndaha'ei ha'e nhande kwera, nhande, nhande mundo por causa que nhande, nhande já respirá, nhande, nhande pytũhẽ ko hape ha amoite upejaike ... pytũhẽ upepe outro mundo, nhanderu, nahdesy kaja'a ha hente poxi, nda ha'ei, hente marangatu upea gwima omõimina nde pepe peteĩ ivarte pe'y ha tomina mitã taí hotera ha emoimĩ pene akaja pypyme nde pe quanta hora?

Pea heiko jajaka pe ype aje ndarekoi na haĩ nda... Enstonses pe jajuka. Upe'a é Xiru nhamõi kaja'a há'ekwera nhanderu, hoga pei osyry peivae, ha'ekwera nhanderu hoga pei osyry peivae, ai

mundo, ha nhande já'íú arã ipeagwy oĩ amoite mina gwygware inhandejairoga.

Upeixa ... jaihuí ha roga jajejaíúramo entonses upea ha roga'í mesma coisa kunhã nhandereko ape carpi nhande roga aje, então upeixa ha'ekwera oĩ o carpi'í oga aje. Ha ha'ekwera moãi ore ko ha'ekwera rimba heta ave ore ko mesma cosa nhande oga pegwa...

Ha'ekwera rimba nhandesy ka'ajaha nhanderu ka'ajala ore ko ha'e rimba kokweti ndorekoi jacaré, ha'e ogwereko sucuri'y, umia arroyo opa onhatumba ore oiko aje ha'ekwera ha'e minha ogwareko umia je upeagwy jaha mombyry ha rupi iteko ihaupy mongajaramo vixo ipoxi aje, entose ha'ekwera umia ha'ekwuea ... tekoha move'ade tekoha move'ade. Entose, pe'y entonse ha'e nhandekwera ndorekoi direito guasu veima oĩ nhande pa peagwy opa pe ndorekoi direito jejaty oĩ ka'agwy 500 metros emredor da mina jerera ha como Arroyo jerera. Porque nhande javyaveiry ko yvy pipe por causa nhande ko jahei jaieterei nhade rekovia je, nhnadereko haveje nde reko haja hejaiterei nhandhomõi ete, gwasuveimave.

Entonse Xiru Paí Kwara nhande resa pe ha reiko nhandendui nhëgaraje, upe ava Poty rusu nhohendui nhëgara ha'í jejupe. Entonses nhanderu teapu guasu tekojara nhã ne nhadepohu, ha ñimbo'ei é como nda rapekwaha ha'ekwera cada ka'aru, ou seja, cada sábado nhande taí katu jareko direito já nhandbo onha mbaraka, nhamborahei hagwã nhadereko oĩava, nhnadereko kwyávo ndarekoi katu marana'ỹ vaerã ai ha'ekwerra ndaindarekoi. Sim xe areko peteĩ tekoja, xe mboruvare opuraheiva oga guasupe amoite yvangara pypegwa xe monhagareko ka va'ekwe, xe ayvu omonhangareko ka oharehe hente ogwahẽ xe aresevy. Xe upea xe xe kovajara amoite, xe anhendui araẽ enterro teko jaragwy oĩ teko jaratejapy guasu nhanderu teko guasu oĩ nhandesy marangatu, oĩ nhandesy

mandereiju kanindé, oĩ nhaderu guarani kaninndé mandereiju kanindé, oĩ verá ponĩ ha'ekwera nhanderru ha nhandesy ha'ekwera oĩ tekojá oĩ nhande, nhande reko jara anhemó'arusũ nhanderu, anhemó'arusũ oĩ nhande jajereko nhande rejoy ave, nhande reko jara ha inha he'i mba'yre nhande haixa rusu, nhande jareko, haixa teko aresã sãkare onhagareko nhandejareko. Upea nhẽgá nhandai nhamboekwarã dai, dai nhãnhãdai peteĩ tekojara nhande jajehu paite atekojaragwy nhemboekenha Xiru Pai Kwará nhẽkarava ava potỹ nhẽkara nde rupi'a. nde rejehu ara ave umĩ ikatu nhãkweragury, umĩ okakwe, umĩ ha'ekwera ogwereco pra nhanderu te ave.

Ha nhande já jareko, mante arave contrato umĩ purahei, umĩ entero ha'ekwera oikwa'avo ohendu`ai opurahei etekojava ndi'e ja por acerteiro, ha'e onhẽ`ẽva e oje onhondive ha'e ogwereco ovypora haixa nhande jareko haixa ave, jareko contato nhandi'e como se fosse peteĩ celular onde e jeynamõi exemplo aje. Entonse oĩandereko jara ape ara vai, ara vai, avaikwera, ava poriahu he'i ha'ekwerave, he'ekwera ojei oĩ temporalpe ha nhandeve ituixa ha'ekwera oje'i ovyrãmo hina nde roga oĩ typoi ho'u aje. Nhnade jareko avary ke'yrsu anhá Fifi, nhande jareko avary ke'yrsu anhangare'i nhnade jareko avary ke'yrsu'i ele kaitereiva oĩ gwanhãgwapy nhande jagwareko gwanhãgwapy mba'egwy nhande jara upea anhãgwapy, ha anhá Fifi, avarike irusu anhãgware, ha'ekwera omoĩnhadeve vyty nhande pytũ hagwã.

Ko vyty omoĩ nhaandevera ko ary nhandejara respira hagwã, upea vae nde reuni ãgwarekwape nhandeve, entose umĩ kwera nhẽgára peteĩ opurahei onhandesy, onhanderu otera mitã'ĩ ohe como poti mbojerroky va'ekwe vytyayjá, jai nhande xupe. Nhande jaipe nda ndive ape nhanderu hape nda ndive nhandesy pea hape mitã ojehe kombu'e agwapy (?) vytyayjá nhandejara, só que nhande entero eui vytyayjá tenho só que pei arando jaiporã cetero ha'e ogwerekovei oĩ opaixagwa teko, upeagwy

jerejorovya umĩa teko jarakwera re he'i entose nem maestro tamem boa escuela porã oĩ enm maética hãngwãixa reigwarẽ upe ikatu hangwãixa reiko arupyty, umĩ vae teko.

Jareko arupy ta xe reko arupyty xe rendirá e he'i mondeva nde rikwa'ai, nde upearã nde, nde reikwa'aimoãi, mboescuela monde ikwa'ata tá xe kwarupyty na xe revyra'e, xe reko johuna, xe revyra'e ta xe reko johuna, xe nde re mondeva entonses upe nhẽ'ẽ nderekoi hangwãixa ndereixa hangwãixa mba'eixapa nde. Nhnade kwera yvyópra nha ndajerekoi 500 anos de vida, nhandekwera yvypóra jareko apenas 100 anos de vida, muito menos nde japoraveima de la cosa, na nhemba'ererovy`a erro ndarekoi mba'eramo. Nhnade jareko mokõi tape, nhnade paí já tape vai upyto aipa jaikotá ota tape, tape porã entonse upea nhande kwera jarekotá ikatui. Nhande he aje he'i mba'yre nhẽ'ẽpe tem hora que nhande, nhande carne fraca jajereko aije, mas só que muito menos nde repensar em primeiro lugar hese mba'eixapa nde reko ta yvy peixa, jeko ha'u nhande kwera jareko mante cimi paí ikatu, como kaiowá e guarani, mba'yre pa jerokotá kwa'a kunhã je jehe por causa que nhande, nhande kwera paí katu ser humano aguentaí mba'asy jajerovy amamante.

Mbo xeajehu jave areko este ãnho opurahei va'ekwe Bororópe o tal de câncer herave nhanderru va'ekwe na mama e o cuiahaixa ha'e ojeroky o xe rundi'e ndatatui. Entonse ha xe reko jave sete ãnhos xe jeroky moãi primeira coisa xa jeroky okwe takwa, jeroky, jeroky upeixa aiko xe tua ha maioria he'e mba'yre je epe xixá xe conhece jerosy, ojapo jerosy puku avati morõntĩ pei tymbire, peixivi nhamõi jakairá, po ojapo va'ekwe jerosy ahexa ko arekoi siete anho omorava eikwe glevape herave e nhanderu Paulito rembyreko avei, entose upea xa e xa ko'apo mante rosy...

Entonse até que agwahẽpeve xe, xe amenda hapyta, xe mãmondi'e xe nda hexai, xe sy vangará pegwa mante, xa reko

jeve cinco ānhos xe, xe sy janhemaīna, janhe ndimaīna ndaikwa'ai je pe xupe entonse xe kakwa'a xe tio, xe tia.

Ai sim, upeagwy ahesa um tempāo aheja mba'yre é hangwā upeagwy xe ani envolver areko jave, xe dezesseis anos, xe ani envolverma mborahei aprofundar hangwā, ani envolver ahexa hangwā mba'egwypa nhande, nhande omano mba'e mba'eixapa nhande jaiko arā mba'egwypa. Entose upiā upepe assim mba'ery ofoca oī xe, xe re kō akyre mba'egwype nhande ojo, ojohe japoko mba'eixa jaiko jei ko harupi upeixa oī xe araha há atopala nhande sy Dona ha'e oīme ko'anga noivixa... oīme aldeia sucuri'ype ndoivixa porā veima oporandu... Dona entonse ha ela xe maestro akwe ha'e ha imena xe exa jeroky siete ānhos, siete ānhospe aje jeroky upepe lá xe ha otopa xe sy a como se ru.

Ome'ēva xeve ko'ē ha ka'akru, conselho xe rekorā haxy mba'e porandu ixupe mba'eixapa teikorā. Ha upeagwy he'i xeve ha'e acredita ahexama avei mombe'u pire aje, entonse ko'anga rupy ramo nhanhamboy keyramo nhande reko, ō entregama javei servício oreve ojeroky 50 familias rendi'e durante sete ānhos, orombo jojahāngwa ore, ore rekoha jeroky he'i o se um maestro ko'anga ha'e três zias peixa mandu'a mba'epa xeve oīme nhande sy rā petēi te nhande mba'oepa oīme nhande rura petēi te nhande mba'apaōpea estezia teko jara duas horasouta omombo joja nē'ē nhandive ha upepe pe'ē mbojojatape nē'ē. mbava e repeikota pe'ēpe moitá nē'ē renonde ha ko'ē ramo gwarā upeipe peiko hangwā he'i aje. Entonses iporā he'i oreve upeia ha entonse he'ixe ko he'i xe roga ape roga ha xe outro oga e mama (?) hape porahei oyta he'i aje, ha poanxa teko rehe oī he'ira e a ha'e oreve araka'e aje ndo ropytai ... noutro aldeiape peixa ore mborahei pea. Entonse upeixa ... jaiko acerto upea ha'e... outra aldeia jei tempāo japo rupi serviço memo, memo pe oia ogwe ko sempre okora haje. Entonse oreve eteziasgwe jejoja nē'ē ērō

ko'arã crente (Marilda Duarte, Bororó). Transcription by Chamirĩ Kwatia Verá Rendiju.

She begins her account like this: How are you all? My name is Marilda Duarte, I live in the Bororó village, which is in Dourados. My name up in the sky is Kunã Poty Rendi. We came from the middle of this land, both the Guaraní and the Kaiowá, we are all from the same place. Our tekoha is this red earth, for in other places it is already different.

When God made this land, He did not stay here. He said to our mother and to the mother of the Great Sun God: "I made this sacred land for the Xiru Paí Kwará, so I cannot stay here on this land," and so He left us here and rose up to the sky to make His home there. He left this land here for us, human beings, and for all the species of animals and plants. He left many things for us, above all the sacred land, which was the first thing, but He also left the seed full of spirit, for us to eat. Without these foods we would not be able to live, for the seeds have always been born from the earth. So all one has to do is plant, just as He did. God, every year, baptizes the earth by sending the frost, and in this way it becomes new and fertile each year. With the frost He performs the baptism of the earth so that it produces food well.

The earth is no longer well, because they have put an end to the forests. Today there are no longer springs the way there used to be, everything has already dried up. Our land no longer has health. It is in the woodland where He walks that the earth is cooled, because the dew falls, and so the earth has moisture so that the seed can be born well, but with the felling of the forest, the earth is no longer happy, it no longer has joy, that is why there is now drought, that is why we have to plant tree seedlings.

We need the woodland, it is there that we seek out medicines, there is medicine in the bark of the trees. If the illness

is not very strong, it heals, but if the illness is very strong we have to add more of the wood's bark, mix it all together, and drink it. If the illness is very strong, mix all the medicines of the woodland, of the marsh, and then you will heal. You take the medicine's bark in mate, in tereré, to heal quickly. If something is hurting, sometimes you don't heal fast, it can take up to ten days to heal well. That is why we have to keep drinking tea made from the leaves, the bark, the medicine. Now many people no longer know anything about the medicines.

In the fields we have many medicines, one is called mamanga, the fig tree, the sap of the fig tree. Drinking it in mate is very good for a pregnant woman, so that the child is not slow to be born, so that she does not suffer. This medicine looks like rubber, it is good for cancer of the uterus. In the marsh there is also a lot of cooling medicine, when we go into the marsh we walk right over the medicine and we don't know what medicine is in the marsh. There are various cooling medicines there for women.

If a young person, whether man or woman, eats the wrong things, depending on what is eaten it can bring suffering. For example, if one eats certain fish like traíra, catfish, piranha, when the time comes to have a child, there will be great suffering. It is the same with the marsh medicines, you cook them and drink them in running water where it drips at the edge of the bank. That is where the good medicines for a racing heart are found. This medicine is for those with high blood pressure. This medicine sits on top of the stones and passes into the earth, it is a great medicine, it goes into the water too. We have all the medicines that help us and that we can drink so as not to fall ill. We have illnesses that frighten us, but if we take these medicines properly, everything passes, and then you can go back to work. You worked, at night you are already tired, you lie down and

cannot sleep, your chest is tight, frightened, it is sick, but in the marsh there is medicine.

There is medicine also in the tall woodland. The karaí speaks of anemia, we say that our blood turns to water, and for this the medicine cannot be bark alone, one must add the bark of the canafístula, the bark of the aroeira, burned and toasted, so that it doesn't become too strong and harsh, so that it gives an appetite. Everyone knows these medicines, one also adds nó-de-cachorro. These are the leading medicines. One also adds the tail of the kanguare, but it is boiled separately, and also the picão. All these medicines are for treating anemia, this mixture of various barks is to make one strong. These medicines are all from the tall, dry woodland.

With the loss of the forest we need to plant, because the owner of our life said that if we want a renewed land we need to sow, to plant the seed of the forest again. Here, for example, we have the stream, and along its banks there is no longer any forest. Only far off in the back there is a small patch of woodland, so we have to plant around it canafístula, aroeira, jatobá, whatever fruits we eat. That way we will have shade, it will stay cool, and the water and its owner will rejoice.

The water has an owner, we only drink water from above, we do not drink from the spring of the original source. This original water is from another world, it is not from our world, because we breathe. There, we do not breathe, in that water over there it is another world. Our father, our mother, and the mermaid are very fierce beings, they are not sacred beings. So that you understand, put water in a bucket, a child comes and falls in face down. That child can even drown and die quickly, because water has no branch to hold on to, it kills you fast. This is Xiru nhamõĩ kaja'a, it is the world of the waters. It is their world. That is why they do not drink this water, the running water is the world of the kaja'a

mermaids and we drink there from the spring. It is from there that we must drink, so that we will not drink from their house.

For example, here is a house of grass, and their house is like that too. They have many animals, *nhanderu kaja'a* and *nhandesy kaja'a*, there is alligator, anaconda, fish. Everything that lives in the water are their animals, they are the ones who care for these animals. On dry land all the animals also have an owner, that is how they are. They are the owners of all the animals that live in the water, but the water is running out, that is why they are not happy, because all the woodlands are being felled. It's just that we have the right and the duty to plant the forest again around the streams and at the springs.

We are no longer happy because we are abandoning our culture, our way of being. The *Xiru Kwará* is no longer hearing our prayers, our songs, the *ava Potyrusu* is no longer listening to our voice. They are sad with us.

In the old days, we prayed every day, today that no longer happens. We no longer have the *teko jara*. I have the *teko jara*, the one who sings up in the sky. He sent me to care for people. I receive all the people who come to me, I do not listen only to the people of my own *teko jara*, I have to listen to all the *teko jara* in order to be a caretaker of lives.

There are several *teko jara hy'apyguasú*, there is *ñandesy marangatu*, there is *ñandesy mande reju*, there is *kanindé*, there is *nhanderu guarani*, *kanindé marindeju*, there is *vera ponhy nhanderu* and *nhandesy* of the *teko jara*. There is *teko jara anhemôã rusu nhanderu*. We have our queen *haxaruasu*, we have *hacha teko*, who takes care of us, with her prayer. We cannot exclude any *teko jara*, we all stand beside the *teko jara*, we cannot abandon them. All those who went there are the *ñanderu*, we need to keep in contact with them, because they

know and understand the prayers. They communicate among themselves.



We also have the one who takes care of the storms that come knocking everything down, there are those who take care of our

breath, there is a prayer for that too. It may be a ñandesy who cleanses the body of the youngest one who dances, the yvyraiia. We are all yvyrayja, only those, the oldest men or women, are the wise ones, and it is in them that we need to believe, in this teko jara. Your teacher must teach you well so that you may reach that point, so that you may attain the sacred, and for this reason, you do not learn only from the teaching you receive. We attain this formation of life so that we may live well. If you do not believe in yourself, you may suffer (Marilda Duarte, Bororó).

Seeds, Land, and Living Well: Kaiowá and Guarani Spiritual Technologies

The purpose of this part of the book is to discuss our Kaiowá and Guarani spiritual technology as epistemic knowledge, which, in my view, is ignored by the so-called civilized world. I will thus continue the reflections on the sustainability of life discussed in the previous chapter, and in this present chapter I will focus on three axes: seeds, the tekoha, and living well.

At the outset, it is important to note that these axes are treated as sacred beings, as possessors of spirits, and, from the perspective of Kaiowá and Guarani sustainability, I will guide the reflections on the importance of these axes for maintaining our way of existing in the world, and on the care we must take so that the seeds, the land, and our living well may multiply with quality, so that the perpetuation of species and of beings becomes possible, in an environment with healthy life on this planet that came to be called Earth.

First, it is important to recall, together with our elder women and men, the ancient times, when our people were free from colonizing evil. In ancient times, to make a field, there was an entire ritual, both in the preparation of the soil and in the planting of the seeds. Today, however, few people prepare their land in the traditional way. All the work of the field was organized by family groups, each with its own role. The men prepared the soil and planted, while the women and children tended and harvested. Traditionally there was (and still is) an appropriate month and moon, both for planting and for harvesting.

There was a particular way of storing the traditional seed for the following year's planting. It was knowledge that had to be

followed, passed down through the teachings of the elders, from generation to generation. This communal work was carried out only within family contexts, in the form of *puxirõ* (*mutirão*, collective labor). It was common among the older Kaiowá and Guarani to call people together to carry out work that required many hands.

The factor underlying this system is unity, Kaiowá and Guarani spirituality. Because it is communal, it cannot be done alone. When we were created to admire the earth, not everything was ready-made; it was necessary to create the things that the *mba'ejára* (owners of beings) left for us, especially food, and that is why we gathered together singing so that the foods we needed would be born. It was by singing for long hours that *Avati Morofĩ* (white corn) was born, which my ancestors cared for as if it were a child. To this day people sing to gladden it, so that there may be a good harvest.

In ancient times, Mother Earth herself required the Guarani and Kaiowá to live and work together, since the circumstances of the time demanded this form of bond in order to carry out hunting and planting. Just as a tree alone cannot survive healthy and happy, still less can human beings. That is why the Kaiowá and Guarani seek to live together, both in festivals and rituals and in work, which has the harvest and celebration as its purpose. It is in this context that we seek, in the elders who still pray, the inspiration to strengthen the young people and the whole community, so that they may be as productive as their ancestors were.

Seeds: A Source of Life and Resistance

Seeds are living beings, full of life, full of secrets, and full of the sacred. During this research of mine, it became very clear

that seeds are the beings responsible for the perpetuation of species and of all living beings of the spiritual world, within the cosmic world of which we are a part. They possess a complex spiritual technology capable of dying and reviving, of bearing fruit and feeding the other living species of planet Earth.

For us Kaiowá, full life will only exist if seeds continue to exist, but for that we need to think of ways to recover our territories, so that we can practice our way of being and living, which is interconnected with the beings and spirits that inhabit the cosmos alongside our existence and with whom we maintain the communion of life. The seed is our source of strength and sustenance, and it is responsible for the human essence. In this way, it holds within its spirituality the continuity of life, of the most varied species, and sustains all other beings. The seed is the source of the sustainability of life.

The word *semente* [seed], in the Portuguese language, comes from the Latin *sementis*,⁷ and refers both to the seed of a fruit and to any cause that permits the creation of something. Thus, the term seed is applied to the creation of life, of a fruit, or of an individual, but is not used in a strictly biological sense; it allows us to understand the origin of vital processes and indicates that in the cycles of nature there is always an originating cause, that is, a germ.

In dialogue with Mr. Jorge Gomes, a leader and Ñanderu of Pirakuá Village, in Bela Vista, I was able to reflect on and deepen the concept of the seed in our Kaiowá and Guaraní worldview. During our conversations, the Ñanderu revealed that:

The seed is very important and there are many kinds of it in the forest, it is everywhere. But it does not exist only in the forest, the seed is just like us. I consider myself a seed, I am here because of

7 Definition from the Oxford Languages dictionary

my father and I consider myself his seed. I am the seed of my father, who no longer exists here in this world (Ñanderu Jorge Gomes, Pirakuá).

Through the Ñanderu's reflection, I was led to reflect that we are all seeds; our sons and daughters, our grandsons and granddaughters, are our seeds. But not only that — I also thought that teachers, both men and women, who go on multiplying the knowledge of life, are also seeds multiplying life, and so each person leaves behind their seed, which will germinate and produce life in this world.

Observing the seeds of plants, one can notice an enormous variety of colors, shapes, and sizes, just as happens with people, who are Black, white, Asian, tall, short, thin, heavy-set. Seeds are the same way — diverse, colorful, with an enormous variety of ways, of shapes, of possibilities of existence.

Speaking with the Ñanderu, Ñandesy, and elder men and women during this research, it became very clear that we, Kaiowá and Guarani, understand that human beings have spirit, and so do seeds, and that is why the seed strengthens us and makes our existence possible. Thus, seeds have a soul and have an owner, and their strength and spirit are manifested through prayers. When we pray, the owners of the seeds come to bless us; without them we could not live. It is the *jara* (owners) of the seeds who bring us health and life, from childhood until we grow old, which is why it is so important to cultivate them so that we may have healthy foods, such as *mbojape* (roasted corn), *pamonha*, and cassava. These traditional foods, produced from seeds, are what give us health and joy.

Thus, we Kaiowá and Guarani consider seeds to be a precious gift from Ñanderu. The conversations shared with the participants of this research made me recall the meaning of seeds

for our people. I remembered the story told by my ancestors that Ñanderu sent Pa'i Tembeju to walk beneath the earth, and wherever he passed, the plant species were born. In this walk of the germination of life, the sacred Avati Morontĩ arose, which carries in the germ of its being the spiritual power to beautify, to perfume, and finally to become food so that we may survive.

That is why we, Kaiowá and Guarani, consider that all seeds are gifts from Ñandejara, who sent us these beings possessed of a spiritual technology capable of dying and being reborn, generating fruits that satisfy our hunger, feed Mother Earth and the other species of nature, besides strengthening us spiritually as an indigenous people.

Observing the planting rituals during this research, I noticed that for us, seeds, like any other being, require care and attention. Thus, for the Kaiowá and Guarani, caring for the seed is essential, because it is the seed that determines the continuity of life on the planet. Caring for these beings with all love, affection, and respect is what will guarantee the continuity of our lives and the lives of other beings.

Our people believe that if Jakaira (owner of the white corn) does not allow the spirit of the seed to return to the world of people, then our earthly journey will come to an end. So, in order to prevent this from happening, every year a baptism and planting ceremony is held, carried out by certain elder men and women of our people, who sing and pray throughout all the stages of the seed's handling and planting.

Thus, they pray as they clear the soil, as they loosen the earth, and they pray for the rain that must come to nourish Mother Earth. Next, the seed of the Avati Morõntĩ is laid in the lap of Mother Earth, who will nourish it, making it grow healthy in every respect. Throughout its growth, the field is tended and

managed through our spiritual technology. Certain guidelines must therefore be followed — for example, women who are pregnant or menstruating are advised not to enter the planting area, so that the spirits present there will not wish to enter their womb. Should a pregnant or menstruating woman enter the field, the crop turns yellow and may even die.

As time passes, and with proper management through Kaiowá and Guaraní spiritual technology, the seed is nourished by the whole of this spirituality and develops in a healthy way. When harvest time arrives, further spiritual technological management comes into play, in which the male and female prayer-leaders, chosen people, gather so that the first harvest may be carried out. On this occasion, everyone rises before Pa'i Kwará (the Sun God) and goes to harvest the food with great joy and tranquility. They then bring the harvest home, where the women tend to the corn to prepare xixa (a traditional drink) and the men prepare the nhemongarai (baptism).

In this way, the baptism ritual of this spiritual being, the Avati Morontĩ, begins — that is, the Jerosy Puku and Mbyky, in which the whole people rejoice and lament for the new dawn. In this festival, teaching and the sharing of knowledge occurs from generation to generation; there is no distinction of persons and/or of sex, and everyone, men and women alike, are active participants in the process. And it is in this way that the moments lived and rooted in these spirits make us strong and powerful, both physically and spiritually.

During my observations and experiences in the planting and harvest rituals, and during my conversations with the elder women and men, I reflected that if even we are seeds, we must consider that these beings are gifts from Ñanderu, for they have the power to reproduce a true miracle, that is, to give life. The techniques used by these beings are of an immeasurable

magnitude, since, as they are born, grow, ripen, and dry, they go through a process of engagement with the four elements of nature (earth, water, air, and fire), and these elements help them constitute their being through this invisible force that I call spirit.

Reflecting on the importance of seeds as living beings, I see that the many existing species carry with them this vital energy, which I cannot classify but which I can understand as being our spiritual technology. The whole process these beings go through, from their germination to the stage in which they satisfy our hunger, is a divine, sacred phenomenon that allows us existence and strengthens us as a people.

When seeds are exposed to smoke for a long time, they often lose their natural color, turning black or grayish. One might then think that the seed no longer has life in it, but in truth it has allowed itself to be painted, smoked, so that within its soul it might be protected from any and all harm that might keep it from germinating again. This process of handling the seed so that it can be stored for future plantings is also part of our complex spiritual technology.

It is this wisdom, this essence, that makes me think and carries me into the ecstasy of reverie when I immerse myself in this context, which for me is more than sacred — it is, in a certain way, supernatural, because in seeking meanings for this natural phenomenon, I encounter the teachings of my people, that everything that exists has a soul, has a jara, and, in particular, the seeds, which are responsible for giving life to all other living beings, making us dependent on this being so small and yet so powerful.

From this perspective, dialogue with the author Antonio Carlos Sant'Ana Diegues seems quite fitting; he states that biodiversity, for indigenous peoples, is not simply a natural

resource but a set of living beings that carries symbolic value, integrated into a complex cosmology. According to the author, in the worldview of these populations, humans, spirits, plants, and animals form part of the same world (DIEGUES, 2000). Ñanderu Jorge Gomes's thinking converges with this perspective when he reflects:

Our soul is speech, that is, nhě'ẽ, and Ñanderu gave this nhě'ẽ also to the seeds and plants, and that is why we must pray and sing so that they may be joyful, and sing too, and speak among themselves. The karai are the ones who do not understand what they say, who do not stop to listen to what they say. Father Xa'ĩ is the owner of many plants, and he had chigoe fleas in his foot, so he was cleaning himself and the blood fell to the ground, and that is how the strawberry was born, which is why it is full of little seeds. Wherever the owner of the plants walks, a plant is born. But there is also the plant of the yvaga (sky), the plants of the yvaga sing and bring the seeds down to the earth; in soul and in speech they descend to the earth. It is beautiful to see with our own eyes! (Ñanderu Jorge Gomes, Pirakuá).

Reflecting more deeply on our spiritual technology, the elder women and men who contributed to this research recalled that in the old days there were none of the farming tools that exist today, but Ñanderu would call the frost to dry out the forest, and we would perform the great prayers so as to be able to burn the plot where the planting would take place. According to these accounts, at that time we already had mastery of fire and burned only exactly where we intended to plant. Once the land had been prepared, the traditional Kaiowá and Guaraní tool was made for planting the seeds. This tool is made from aroeira or peroba wood and is called sarakwá.

The reflections built together with the participants in the research also revealed that each seed has its own time to be planted, to sprout, and to grow, in addition to specific handling

required for each type of plant. For example, purple-husk corn needs five months, taking five days to sprout. With beans and rice, on the other hand, small planting holes are made, and whatever fits between three fingers is placed in them — on average three or four seeds.

Thus, before the arrival of non-indigenous people, fields were made through the control of fire, and the same held true for dealing with insect attacks and other pests. On such occasions, negotiation took place between the prayer-leaders and the *jara* of these beings. At that time, nature provided food in abundance for indigenous peoples; there was a diversity of plants that supplied medicines and fruits, a diversity of animals for hunting, and a variety of birds and fish that helped maintain a good diet. In this scenario of such richness, the Kaiowá and Guaraní lived in communion with nature, respecting its natural cycles, working the land, and producing a great wealth of food.

From this perspective, Kaiowá and Guaraní prayer-leaders negotiate, through prayer and song, with the *jara*, the owners of the levels that make up the world, so that, despite the current devastation of indigenous lands, the forest, the medicines, the animals, and the produce of the fields continue to be born. The anthropologist Levi Pereira states that:

The Kaiowá world is “unnatural”; it does not reproduce naturally, it must be created and constantly re-created through the inoculating action of the shaman, awakening in plants, animals, people, and social formation the will to rise up and, in rising up, to affirm its existence (PEREIRA, 2014, p. 228).

Regarding the action of the shaman, according to the Kaiowá historian Izaque João, “it exists so that the plant may rise up and, in this way, not cause social or personal imbalance” (JOÃO, 2011, p. 29).

Thus, our spiritual technology establishes a profound relationship and a constant concern among our elder men and women to maintain our customs, such as the Jerosy Puku and Mbyky, so that during this period the entire community becomes involved in carrying out these rituals, which guarantee the continuity of the seeds — many of them already nearly vanished because of the advance of the colonizers and their infertile minds, as Mr. Jorge Gomes states:

We were independent, we had seeds of mbakuku, catador beans — there were seeds of every kind, but many disappeared with the arrival of the karái, white men who came to colonize. And not only us, but also nature, which was and is being exploited throughout its richness. The seeds, in their smallness, hide within their being material the sublime science of remaking life. The spirit of the seed is supreme, it is vital (Ñanderu Jorge, Pirakuá).

Avati Morontĩ, the Mburuvixa of the Seeds, and the Jerosy Puku



Figure 5. The mburuvixa (leader) of the seeds. Source: Xiru Karái Archive.

As we have seen, the seeds are spiritual and divine beings that guarantee the existence of all other beings; however, there is

one seed that for us, the Kaiowá and Guarani, holds great importance for the balance of all the other seeds: the white corn, Avati Morontĩ. For us, white corn is considered the mburuvixa (leader) of the seeds, since it has skin, flesh, and a heart, where its soul dwells. Without that soul, the seeds are not born, they are dead, and this is why we pray from the preparation of the soil through to the harvest, with prayers, songs, and dances.

According to the accounts of the female and male elders, Avati Morontĩ (white corn) is the species that possesses the greatest spirit, the one that gives vitality to people's lives. According to Mr. Jairo Barbosa, of the Panambizinho Indigenous Land, a rezador (prayer leader) of that community and of the communities of Gwyrá Kamby'i and Laranjeira Nhanduru, this species of corn is Jakaira, the father of the seeds. The rezador tells us that this corn is so sensitive that it must be treated as if it were a child, from the preparation of the soil through to its harvest, when the baptism of the seeds is performed, bringing back the fruits that have germinated.

The festivities related to white corn and its owner take place once a year, since they must be prepared over a long period of time. Care for the preparation of the soil begins first with spiritual preparation, and only the people chosen at the previous festival may plant the Avati Morontĩ, which is a divinity for the continuity of the Guarani and Kaiowá.

Thus, once the person responsible for this work has been chosen, the rezador who will keep the prayer of the Avati Morontĩ is invited so that, in the month of August, this rezador may carry out the marking of the area to be planted. This happens in a deeply spiritual way, with the rezador walking and praying in circles and/or in a square from the hour the sun rises until the sun sets. In this way, the chosen area will be sown in September with the seeds that were baptized previously.

As Mr. Nailton Aquino, *puraheita* (singer and *rezador* of *kotyhu*), tells us, the prayer continues after planting so that the corn will grow, putting out its little ears (*bonequinhas*) and healthy silk. If this happens, he will know that all is well, that it has been blessed by *Ñanderu Guasu*, the great God, and that future generations will still come. If everything unfolds this way, *Kaiowá* and *Guarani* life and the *Kaiowá* and *Guarani* world will continue.

When the harvest season draws near, a great feast is organized: the *Jerosy Puku*. The whole community grows euphoric awaiting this great day, and internal and external dialogue begins in search of the food that will be served to the guests. The young people who will do the harvesting before dawn get ready before sunrise, and on this day, while the young people go to the fields, the women go to the prayer house, clean it, fetch the pounding mortar, and prepare everything to receive the corn with much singing and prayer.

Then, when the corn arrives, people sit down, and between one conversation and another, the work gets done, along with teaching and learning, because the children, the women, the elders, and the people invited to take part in this ritual are all there. The whole day is spent talking, recalling things that were lived, and telling stories of courtship, marriages, children, and journeys. While the fire is being prepared, the corn is pounded together with sweet potato, and during this process people dance and rejoice so that the spirit of the corn will fill the space with its scent and its presence.

Alongside all this festivity, the preparation of the celebration's decorations goes on. The men travel far to gather cedar branches to make the *yvyray* (path), along which all the people invited are led into the great prayer house, where the great *Jerosy Puku* prayer will take place. It is at this moment that

the baptism of the white corn and of all the seeds occurs, along with that of the children and/or adults who have been invited.

Nowadays this feast lasts three days, so that on the first day prayer continues through the whole night, with brief pauses to drink unfermented xixa. This prayer generally begins at four in the afternoon and only ends around five in the morning, when the rays of the sun travel along the yvyray and reach the rezador, who is there with the seeds, the food to be consumed, and the children.

There, during this sacred and blessed moment, a great silence falls, and only the faint murmur of the rezador communicating with Pai Kwarahy, the great sun, can be heard very softly. He is one of those responsible for the rebirth of all beings existing in the world, since it is He who is responsible for feeding all the beings that inhabit the Earth with His powerful energy.

After this moment, the hour of rest arrives, and while the food is being prepared, the children who have already slept and are rested go on repeating the ritual they absorbed during the night for the younger children, who are looked after by the older ones. On this occasion we can observe how a true intergenerational school takes shape in the midst of these sacred moments. This is non-school indigenous education.

During the day, relatives visit one another, and at nightfall they return so that the feast can continue, such that on this day the kotyhu is sung and the invitation bow for the next harvest is passed from hand to hand. And so the relatives become drawn in, and between songs and conversations, they spend the night together in union. In this way, the ritual continues until the third day, when it comes to a close, around ten at night, because by

then the xixa is quite fermented. The Jerosy Mbyky is considered the short prayer that closes the harvest cycle.

Unfortunately, the constant attacks on our people and on our tekoha are having a strongly negative effect on our way of being and living. Nowadays, the feasts and rituals that draw on our spiritual technology are happening less and less frequently, since traditional songs are being replaced by the new generations with electronic sounds, and the participation of the male and female elders is often restricted to the family of whoever is hosting the feast.

So today, the feasts and rituals still happen, but not the way they used to, when we would stay together for a long time, because now everything depends on FUNAI and on our allies, and we can never gather enough food for many days. Besides that, many of the participants are workers in the private sector and public employees who have set hours to keep.

So everything has changed; our traditional culture has had to adapt to the context we live in. We have cut everything back, we no longer have time to pray, everyone has to work in different places. Even so, I believe that if we had our roça (garden/field) the way it used to be, with plenty of food, we could also have more days of feasting, of mongarai (baptism), of consecrating the seeds, so as to have more healthy food and health for all our people.

By growing stronger, we will have greater food production, making possible the return of the animals we used for food and for obtaining medicines, as well as the abundance of certain animal species, such as chickens, ducks, pigs, goats, among others. In this way, we will be able once again to hold our festivities such as the Jerosy Puku in their fullness, since we will have food to sustain us through long days of prayers and songs.

Valdomiro Oswaldo Aquino, political and traditional leader of the Panambizinho Village, said to me during this research, as we were walking through the bush:

In Paulito's time, everyone prayed a lot. It really was prayer the whole time! Back then there was never a skinny child, no one ever went to the mission, there was no need! Because everyone had Avati Morotĩ food and the children were all baptized (Valdomiro Aquino, Panambizinho).

On another occasion, in a conversation with Mr. Nelson Concianza, the Keeper of the Crosses, I heard him say: "Now there are no more Kaiowá." For a brief moment I did not understand what he meant. And he went on:

Every boy nowadays, still a baby, is already messing around with women, no longer has a tembetá⁸, so who is going to keep the Cross? Here there is the Cross of Paulito, of Ireno, of Lauro, my father. If there is no more Kunumi Pepy, what am I going to do? (Nelson Concianza, Panambizinho).

I asked him what to do. He told me: "We have to go back to planting Jakaira, before the last ones who know how to pray and perform the boys' ritual are gone. We have to teach, otherwise it will all come to an end."

And it is precisely against this spiritual weakening that we fight; it is for this continuity of life that we resist. We, the Kaiowá and Guarani Kwery, are concerned not only with our human life, but we are also concerned with the natural balance, we are concerned with spiritual lives, and the seeds give us examples of resistance when they respond to every attack and, uninhibited and exuberant, make use of their spiritual techniques and teach us generosity.

This sacred resistance makes the seeds come back to life when we provide these beings with spaces for regeneration, but

for that it is essential to secure the reclaiming and recovery of our territories, so that our seeds may thereby be shielded from the non-spiritual technology of non-indigenous people, who genetically modify the seeds, bringing about their spiritual death. This technology of the whites holds no interest for us, because it puts an end to the diversity of beings, turns everything into one single thing, and we indigenous people fight for a diverse world, one in harmony.



Tekoha: Our Sacred Land Crying Out for Help

Through the accounts of our female and male interlocutors, I was able to grasp how important and sacred the seed is for the Kaiowá and Guaraní people, especially the seed of the great

white corn, Avati Morontĩ. It is this seed that makes the existence of life possible in all its harmony and fullness. But the seed, in order to germinate and give life, needs to be laid to rest in the sacred lap of our great Mother: the Earth.

During the conversations with the female and male elders taking part in this research, I was able to recall the story of when Ñanderu Guasu set out to create this world, that is, the planet Earth: he went along singing and praying with his kurusu⁹ in a circle, just as our Ñanderu and the whole Kaiowá and Guaraní people do during the Jerosy.

Thus, wherever he set his foot, land was created, and after having created the land, the Great God went on creating all the things of this planet. Once everything was ready, He created us, the Kaiowá and Guaraní, to admire his creation. But today, our Mother Earth is crying out for help; she is tired, she has suffered, she aches, and she is saddened by so much neglect and exploitation of her natural riches.

The conversations built up over the course of this research made me recall the life of my ancestors, when in the past we all lived, men and women alike, in harmony with our great Mother Earth. She fed us, treated us with care and affection, and gave us everything we needed; but with the invasion of the colonizers, from the sad historical date of 1500 onward, we, the original peoples, were marginalized, exterminated, and robbed. They took our land from us, and in doing so they took from us everything we held most sacred.

With great sadness and indignation, today I see that the supreme vitality of Mother Earth was, and still is, being brutally plundered by the so-called colonizers, who to my mind are murderers not only of people, but of all living beings and of the

9 Kaiowá religious instrument.

spiritual beings that inhabit our tekoha. It is a cruelty beyond measure, a disturbing violence, and an assault on life.

In the course of the research, together with my interlocutors, I recalled that in our region of Dourados, since the 1920s, with the arrival of the Dourados Agricultural Colony (CAND) and the establishment of the Erva Mate Laranjeira extractive company, we were, and still are, being dispossessed and expelled from our original lands. They arrived in the name of progress, in the name of development, but in truth, what they did was to violate our existence as an indigenous people.

The colonizing invaders confined our ancestors to small areas, called indigenous reservations, and we, unwilling to accept this as our population grew, began the struggle to return to or reacquire our tekoha, our territories of life, which today are in the hands of farmers and large landowners. Only by reclaiming our sacred territory can we live and exist as a strong and healthy people.

This process has caused immense wear and suffering for my people, so much so that many deaths have already occurred in the midst of this struggle. And it was not only people who were decimated by the colonizers; our entire forest, our cerrado, our wetlands, our animals, everything that has life is threatened by this agribusiness policy of destroying everything in order to plant a single thing. Today, all the species of plants and animals existing in the environment are being replaced by soy and genetically modified corn. That is why our struggle is important: it is for life, it is for diversity, it is for care and love toward Mother Earth and all the beings that exist within her.

From this perspective, researchers who have worked in Kaiowá and Guaraní territory agree that a healthy tekoha is fundamental to the continuity of my people's way of being and

existing (BRAND, 1998). Precisely because it is this village, the tekoha, that is the legitimate space for carrying out the rituals, songs, and dances, the liturgies that produce the cosmogony within Guarani and Kaiowá life. It is the necessary space in which to live, plant, and develop (PEREIRA, 1995).

According to scholars of my people, this space also provides the community with the elements and raw materials needed for the production of typical crafts, traditional food, and the spaces in which indigenous knowledge is passed on. Above this tekoha there would only be the place of immortality, the "land without evil," a space where the human condition is set aside so that the human being may attain the condition of a "God" (PEREIRA, 1995; MELIÀ, 1987).

The conversations with the female and male elders during this research made clear the importance of a healthy, balanced tekoha for us to be able to live out the fullness of the rituals and to honor the beings left to us by Ñandejara. It is only in this tekoha kwery that we can hold our other feasts, ones without a religious purpose, such as the xixa we make to celebrate birthdays or other commemorative dates, such as Indigenous Peoples' Day, for example. In short: it is only with our tekoha healthy and in balance that we can go on existing in our essence.

It is because of the immense importance of the tekoha for our people that we fight, day after day, to reconquer our territories, so as not to lose the beings that live alongside us and that give us strength, and also to guarantee the original right of both the peoples and the environment we inhabit. And this struggle needs to be strengthened more and more, because what we see is a constant assault on the legislation currently in force in our country, which is being continually threatened by lawmakers who insist on amending it to serve their own selfish, particular

interests, causing irreversible harm to populations and to the environment.

In this way, based on the considerations developed in this research, I can affirm that, for us, good land is the land where our ancestors are, where we can carry out our rituals and sow the seeds within the bosom of our Mother Earth. For us, there is no such thing as bad land; there is sick and mistreated land, wounded and hurt by the many technologies of death that agribusiness cruelly imposes on her.

For us, well-cared-for land never becomes infertile or sterile; it stops producing only in places where all its energies have already been exhausted through the indiscriminate use of its driving forces, yet it remains humble and lives out the process of resilience with supremacy, patience, and effectiveness.

The land is capable of reconstituting itself with the help of the spirits that inhabit its depths and its surroundings, and for this reason, we, the Kaiowá and Guarani, believe that as long as we remain steadfast in our pursuit of techniques arising from the spiritual world, we hold the hope of a full life for ourselves, indigenous peoples, and for all the other beings that inhabit this world.

Teko Porã: Kaiowá and Guarani Good Living

Having thought and reflected together with my people on the importance of the seeds, of the powerful white corn, and of our tekoha for the life and existence of my people, I now present some ideas about our Kaiowá and Guarani way of living, which is based on life lived in an organized and balanced way, through love and respect among all beings. This particular way of life is known as good living; for us, the Kaiowá and Guarani, it is known as teko porã.

Teko porã, in the context of my people, is conceived from harmony with the whole cosmos, with all beings. Our good living means being able to have living seeds, living land, flowers coloring the universe, birds flying joyfully over our tekoha. It means having our children grow up happy and healthy, and our male and female elders living out not merely the utopia of a return to the sacred land, but the assurance that food is for life and not for death.

Good living, teko porã, is being able to worship the jara kwery (owners of beings) without being judged and condemned as wrongdoers by other religions; it is having time to honor the creation of "God," which today, unfortunately, is damaged, with few species left to admire. It is being able to believe in another possible world, where our actions as peoples who care for nature can influence and reverse the course of the history told by the wise lords of a perverse society, one that silently kills thousands of people.

This is because we, the Guarani and Kaiowá, are not merely part of nature, but are nature itself. We do not think the way non-indigenous people do, who look at nature as an abstract subject, lifeless and without rights. In our understanding, nature is us and we are nature. So when we harm nature, we are harming ourselves.

Some theorists concerned with the continuity of life devote their research to discussing this theme. These scholars say that, in the context of post-developmental discussions, efforts are multiplying toward a reconstruction and overcoming of the conceptual foundation, the practices, the institutions, and the discourses of development. And we, indigenous peoples, are showing possible paths by which this reconciliation with nature might become possible, that is, with humanity itself, through involvement (envolvimento) rather than development

(desenvolvimento). As the great quilombola intellectual Nêgo Bispo says, we, traditional peoples, do not want development, we want involvement in the building of our relationships.

According to the intellectual and bem viver researcher Alberto Acosta, bem viver, or *buen vivir*:

presents itself as an opportunity to collectively build new ways of life. *Buen vivir* is not an original invention, nor a novelty of the political processes of the early twenty-first century in the Andean countries. Nor is it a kind of superstition or magic potion for all the world's ills. *Buen vivir* is part of a great search for alternative ways of life forged in the heat of humanity's struggles for emancipation and for life (ACOSTA, 2016, p. 208).

In this sense, without downplaying Western contributions, the heterodox views that focus on "alternative developments" must be overcome, when what is increasingly necessary is to generate "alternatives of involvement." This is what *buen vivir* is about, or bem viver, or indeed teko porã, a concept developed by indigenous peoples for thinking about life in balance and harmony. We know it is evident that the non-indigenous world is searching for answers on how to live well, but what is needed is willingness and political and social action.

It is worth highlighting here other humanist contributions, such as that of the Indian ecofeminist Vandana Shiva, whose work has helped spread the debate on bem viver throughout the world. According to this author, the economic and cultural model of the West was conceived through the colonization of women, of native peoples, and of their lands. Shiva thus criticizes modern conceptions of development, economics, progress, and science, drawing attention to the urgent need to build a paradigm that makes possible the survival and a dignified coexistence of the peoples and beings of the earth (MIES AND SHIVA, 2007).

Leonardo Boff, the Brazilian theologian and philosopher, offers the reflection that *bem viver* points toward an ethic for the community, not merely for the individual. According to this author, *bem viver* presupposes a holistic, integrative vision of the human being, immersed in the great earthly community that includes, besides the human being, the air, the water, the soil, the mountains, the trees, and the animals. According to him, it means being in deep communion with Pachamama (the Earth), with the energies of the universe, and with the spiritual world (BOFF, 2017).

Reflecting together with the female and male elders, I found that for us *bem viver* does not mean living like the *karaí*. For us, the Kaiowá and Guaraní, *bem viver*, or rather, *teko porã*, is based on being able to sing, dance, and cultivate the land without concern for large-scale production, but rather in a quantity sufficient to sustain material and spiritual life, both our own (human) life and that of the other beings, in their own material and spiritual lives.

Because we hold a holistic worldview, we cannot understand how to live without diversity, without spirituality, without care for one's neighbor. In this sense, we need to join our efforts and overcome the monocultural model in every respect, and to do so, I believe it is necessary to move beyond the conceptual foundation of development, as well as to change our attitudes and our relationships, because the planet and its inhabitants are crying out for life.

And to conclude, I say that without seeds, without their spiritual techniques, without our *tekoha*, and without our Mother Earth, our survival is impossible, just as is the survival of any being, for we form a cycle dependent on one another: we depend on the seeds, on the land, and on spirituality, and these

in turn depend on us and on the other species of beings. Thus, if we are not in connection, without this jopoi, we will perish.

Finally, I close this text with the definition of bem viver, teko porã, together with the critique of the non-indigenous way of life that affects Kaiowá and Guaraní bem viver, developed and expressed in the account of Ñanderu Jairo Barbosa:

Teko porã is eating well, without poison. It is being able to pray, sing, and dance, to hold our Jerosy with good food. It is living without being a slave to work. The white man is a slave to work, and he makes us that way too. Look, our children nowadays don't even play anymore. They go to school, the young person goes to the company and doesn't even learn to pray anymore (Jairo Barbosa, Panambi).



Figure 6. Jerosy Puku, 2014. Source: Xiru Karáí Archive.



Kaiowá and Guarani School Education and Interculturality: Tensions, Dialogues, and the Strengthening of Traditional Knowledge

In this last part, having previously reflected on Kaiowá and Guarani sustainability and spiritual technologies, I proceed to a discussion of these traditional knowledges of my people, from my own point of view as an educator and tireless fighter for a school education specific to my people.

First, it must be pointed out that perspectives on intercultural education are always in dispute, and today they are being challenged through the struggles of indigenous peoples, aiming at a transformation of the ways in which knowledge is constructed, one grounded in traditional knowledge and respectful of the self-determination of peoples.

In this sense, this chapter aims to reflect on the specific features of intercultural efforts for indigenous peoples, their tensions, dialogues, and disputes, in order to raise questions and aspects related to this process in school education in the Panambizinho tekoha. At the same time, I have also cast an eye over the experiences of other indigenous peoples built as community educational spaces.

The proposal is a reflection from the standpoint of a Kaiowá researcher and educator on intercultural processes, a bias of interculturality that has often served as a shallow discourse and as an institutional tool for maintaining the colonizer's policy, since it continues to privilege only one culture, that of the karai (white/non-indigenous people). I seek to discuss how interculturality can be used as a tool strengthened by communities and built on the ground of the territories. For this, my starting point is the questioning reflection of the indigenous

researcher Célia Xakriabá: "How do we turn the weapon that colonized us into a space of subversion as well?" (CORREA, 2018, p. 165).

The diversity of peoples and knowledges is one of the great wonders of the world; this exuberant diversity makes possible the coexistence of cultures and peoples of different ethnic and geographic origins. However, these relations of exchange between distinct cultures generate two-way transformations that may or may not favor the continued existence of the cultures involved, since there is a relation of power imposed by the modern colonial system, which marginalizes peoples who organize themselves socially and territorially in multiple ways. In this way, cultural exchange, known as interculturality, when it occurs between indigenous cultures and Western culture, favors only one side, that is, the side of the whites.

The ethnocentric and Eurocentric reading of the world has left us a trail of violence, exploitation, and dispossession where intercultural education is concerned. We were led to believe that the only way to build intercultural knowledge is from the knowledge of Western peoples; and this is why I understand that the challenges to be faced in building an Indigenous school education that is both intercultural and just for us are enormous.

Maintaining the structure of looking at Indigenous peoples as "the others" and positioning itself as a dominant system that masks this marginalization, interculturality has often been called "official" and is sustained by a matrix that subordinates other forms of knowledge and socio-territorial organization; it must be reiterated that this same interculturality was established by the State and by the knowledge of the *karáí*.

Top-down interculturality is a monocultural interculturality; it is a denial of multiplicity, seeking a hegemony and a

coloniality of knowledge and power that is also expressed in schools, universities, and institutes, making Eurocentric knowledge and concepts predominate. The same occurs with the perspective of official interculturality, as the author Quijano (1992) affirms.

Coloniality is related to the pattern of power in the process of domination through a colonization of the imaginary and through the imposition of a paradigm considered universal, as part of European rationality. In light of this, the author Edson Kaiapó (2019) emphasizes that the school, under national ideology, historically created 'the myth of the generic Indigenous person,' represented by a set of stereotypes that reproduce structural racism and constant marginalization.

In this condition, the State creates mechanisms to control diversity through this interculturality grounded in the same structures of power, without even seeking to create possibilities for policies and actions that combat violations and violence against Indigenous cultures. The law of the *karaí*, that is, the 1988 Federal Constitution, recognized the importance of Brazil's multicultural character, as well as full respect for the original right of Indigenous peoples to their traditional territories, as Daniel Munduruku shows:

The current Federal Constitution addresses the rights of Indigenous peoples in a transversal, broad, and innovative manner, recognizing that the need for special legal protection for Indigenous peoples lies in cultural diversity and not in civil incapacity, which made possible the drafting, in the years that followed, of abundant infra-constitutional Indigenous legislation, granting these minorities the right to ethnic, linguistic, and cultural diversity, without prejudice to their prerogatives as Brazilian citizens (MUNDURUKU, 2012, p. 37)

In this context, a series of initiatives began to be adopted for Indigenous School Education, aiming at a differentiated education (CAVALCANTE, 2017). However, it is important to note that, most of the time, actions guided by a bureaucratic and institutional vision predominated, through a perspective of interculturality that privileges only the interests of the *karaí* and of the Brazilian State itself, to the detriment of the agendas and demands of Indigenous peoples.

Thus, although it enables dialogue and a certain notion of tolerance between different peoples and knowledges, this education does not present itself as an interculturality grounded in the valuing of traditional knowledge and spiritual technologies, still less in the sense of an interculturality of a contra-colonial character that is attentive to the struggles of these peoples.

This process has been gradually questioned in recent decades by curricular proposals in Indigenous schools, as the number of Indigenous women and men teachers has grown, with the orientation of valuing and strengthening the traditions of Native Peoples (KAIAPÓ, 2019).

The increase in the number of Indigenous educators is fundamental for reflecting on Indigenous protagonism through entry into universities, which for Gersem Baniwa Luciano marks “this new era of the vision and attitude of Indigenous peoples in Brazil” (LUCIANO, 2012, p. 137). The author emphasizes that:

In the last 30 years, Indigenous peoples in Brazil, in my understanding, made this decision to invest in education. And the very strong arrival at university is part of this wager: school can be an important instrument for the present and the future of these peoples, in every respect, whether for greater interaction with the surrounding world, with the non-Indigenous world as broadly as possible, which shows the great interest in dialogue and

coexistence, but there are also specific interests, such as improving living conditions in the villages (LUCIANO, 2012, p. 137)

Unlike the vision of the *karaí* and the perspective of institutional bureaucracy, the vision of Indigenous peoples regarding education is multiple and differs in that there exists both traditional Indigenous education and Indigenous school education. Kaiowá and Guaraní Indigenous Education, our own system of education, always begins in the space of the home, of the domestic fire, in festivals and celebrations, where we learned to do things alongside our elders, learning above all to pray and to relate to the spiritual world. It was always the elders, mothers, and fathers who taught the children and the younger ones. In this collective space of the home we also learned many things about the *kokue* (cultivated field).

For us, the Guaraní and Kaiowá, especially the elders, we understand the cultivated field not as suffering, but as leisure. It is there that food is born. It is where we can teach our children our way of being. So, the cultivated field is for us leisure and not work (in the sense of punishment that work carries in the Western concept). What differentiates us from this concept of the white man is that the cultivated field, for us, is leisure, is happiness (PERALTA, 2017, p. 4).

But when it comes to observing the format of Indigenous School Education, one perceives that it is still guided, for the most part, by the ideas and perspectives of the *karaí* and the State, turning the intercultural proposal into an unequal, unjust, and, worse, colonizing process. From this standpoint, I, as a Kaiowá Indigenous educator and researcher, am quite concerned about this predominance of State interests and the impacts this has on our knowledge, which has already been greatly weakened, violated, and marginalized by the Brazilian State. The

school itself wanted to destroy our knowledge. All the knowledge we have kept continues to be violated and may be lost if we do not change the tensions and contradictions propagated by the *karaí* way of being.

The authors Ramalho and Leite (2020) point out that the establishment and construction of the intercultural school occurred in a way that maintained the exercise of preserving State interests, through a colonizing character and an attempt at whitening that gives little value to the cultures, languages, traditions, and rights of Indigenous peoples over their territories. This process immensely affected our ways of sharing knowledge, where many peoples nearly lost their language, many lost their songs, their prayers, and when you lose the language you lose the whole root that surrounds ethnicity.

In an article written years ago, I pointed to this expropriation of knowledge and the violence of the non-Indigenous way of being toward our people:

We have watched much of the Indigenous knowledge that prepared the remedies used to cure humanity become the object of a science that ignores our importance in this process of systematizing knowledge. The most absurd thing of all this is seeing that we were expropriated of our knowledge as a result of an inhumane domination that has inflicted upon us a series of restrictions on the living conditions of Indigenous people, stemming from this contact that was, for us, unequal and abusive (Peralta, 2017, p. 5)

In this context, there are still various difficulties that permeate the school, such as the silencing of the stories told by Indigenous peoples themselves within school curricula, with a colonial view and the mythification and folklorization of native cultures predominating. This is evident both in the fact that we still have non-Indigenous teachers in community schools, and in

the marginalization of traditional knowledge, since teaching materials coming from the State end up reproducing the same logic. The lack of strengthening of the protagonism of literature and materials by Indigenous researchers in schools is a factor that allows this continuum of marginalization to persist.

As an educator I am quite concerned about this, about what interculturality seen from a “mono” view can go on causing us, the native peoples. Because it is the elders, the men and women, who ensure that we still have our language and our songs, having managed to guard them with great care and never opening up so that the white man could discover what we know.

It must be said that when one culture meets another, this could be considered an interculturality, but what kind of interculturality is this? This is the great crux of the question that I raise here: Is interculturality my desiring to know the knowledge of the other? The other knowing my knowledge? Because each one has their own knowledge.

The problem does not lie in sharing our knowledge as different peoples; we have always done this as humanity. However, when this is established from a relationship of a colonizing, hierarchical, and centralizing character, as the State and white culture do, it generates many problems for marginalized groups. The ignorance of the *karái reko* (the white man's way of life) institutes in the school an intercultural character that ends up reproducing practices and movements that fully impact the way of being and living of Indigenous peoples.

But I believe it is possible to destroy this notion of school in this hierarchical format and to think of it instead as a tool through which we can fight for a communal space, in which interculturality is carried out on the basis of our own peoples. I

see that few of us, teachers, actually practice this interculturality built from the valuing of traditional knowledge, of our Indigenous science. Perhaps we end up saying we are doing interculturality, but we end up only translating the white man's knowledge.

In many Indigenous schools there are various events shaped like karaí events, such as the June festival, the graduation ceremony, the Indigenous clothing parade, all in the white man's model. And honestly, I do not know if this is interculturality. White people talk about "interacting," but when we interact within this white model, the karaí culture is so colonizing that we end up forgetting our own. Now I put this in question: How many of our important traditional events and rituals are held and taught in the Indigenous school? Are we not making room for the marginalization of our traditional ways?

The intercultural attempts within Kaiowá and Guaraní Indigenous School Education, in the format in which they have been carried out and conceived, along a single path where the karaí devise things alone and then present the finished project to the Indigenous peoples, is a process understood by our peoples as an inefficient model doomed to failure, besides perpetuating the colonizer's ideal. Therefore, even with some new attempts that have been thought out and theorized, such as, for example, the perspective of critical interculturality as opposed to the functional perspective (CAVALCANTE, 2017), the Kaiowá and Guaraní still do not feel fully included when it comes to building fairer and more dignified intercultural knowledge.

As I have emphasized, these dimensions of interculturality and their historical impacts on our people concern me. I see that this karaí interculturality can bring us a profound betrayal; we give an extra dose of medicine and end up with deep and devastating side effects.

From this perspective, I agree with the author Gersem Baniwa Luciano (2012), when he stresses that, above all, it is necessary to deconstruct the notions and concepts that inferiorize our peoples and that hierarchize the different kinds of knowledge taught in school, so that it is urgent to undo colonizing ideas, in addition to carrying out a process of “true de-education, that is, learning to recognize the mistakes learned in school itself” (LUCIANO, 2012, p. 141).

Building another form of education aimed at destroying the colonization of knowledge is fundamental to opening new spaces and political-epistemological axes for rethinking interculturality, from the standpoint of freedom and respect for other cultures, epistemologies, and forms of knowledge construction, as the author Aníbal Quijano (1992) emphasizes. This type of model brought by the white man ends up being imposed on us, Indigenous educators, sometimes without our having any real notion of the effects it may cause and has already caused. So I remain quite concerned, and we need to think much more about what to do with interculturality. I also understand that we Indigenous people do not need to be intercultural about everything, all the time.

But we are contaminated by things from outside, such that we have already been through destruction, through various kinds of ‘ends,’ and now we are gaining awareness of the effects, even though we have always resisted every process of dispossession of life, of our territories, and of our knowledge. So I remain quite concerned about interculturality, but I also see that if we approach interculturality with respect we can build a more peaceful good way of living, *teko porã* (the good way of living) and *teko vy'a* (the way of being happy).

I agree once again with Gersem Baniwa Luciano (2012), when the author relates that the school institution was

historically imposed on Indigenous peoples as an integrationist and nationalist project, but was permanently confronted and resignified by our peoples as a tool that enables a less asymmetrical dialogue.

Thus, in seeking to confront and resignify the school, it is necessary to place our Indigenous knowledge in transit as the central axis for cultivating a differentiated school. This allows the school to gradually be transformed into an instrument for valuing orality, the knowledge of the eldest people, and the valuing of each people's own ways of knowing and doing education based on their own way of being and existing, which in many cases has moved toward valuing Indigenous languages and the oral knowledge of the elders.

As our relative Baniwa teaches us, only when we strengthen this will a fair and dignified intercultural education be possible, one in which conventional school pedagogies can dialogue symmetrically and coexist with Indigenous pedagogies (LUCIANO, 2012). This is a proposal for a fair and symmetrical dialogue, so that Indigenous knowledge is recognized as scientific, and so that there is an understanding of the educational process as a trajectory that goes beyond the possibilities and limitations of school walls, extending across the whole territory.

As emphasized by the Indigenous author Célia Xakriabá Correa (2018), many traditional women and men teachers say that the school needs to be an interesting place for students, one that should be grounded in the community's knowledge for life, as well as valuing the experiences we live in the territory, where the student needs to understand the inseparability of the body from the territory.

That is why I also understand that interculturality can bring the possibility of sharing knowledge with respect, since I believe that when I can know and respect the culture of the other, this allows another way of thinking and doing interculturality to be built. As our relative Xakriabá says, “The intercultural experience produces a displacement (or a relocation) of thought” (CORREA, 2018, p. 165). Thus, I can continue being myself, without being the other, without wanting to be the other, and without the other imposing itself on me. From this standpoint, Célia Xakriabá Correa (2018) points out:

As happens for the most part in academic production, the teaching materials that reach our schools always privilege theories produced at the center. It is as if the culture of the other were stronger; there is a great fading and devaluing of Indigenous students in the academic environment. Some students go to university and are not considered producers, authors, and interlocutors of knowledge in that setting. But there needs to be a reverse process, which is what I call indigenization. Why not indigenize the other? Why not quilombolize, peasant-ize the other? That would be to exercise what is proposed by the very concept of interculturality (CORREA, 2018, p. 19).

So, interculturality is important, but I think: to what extent is it important for a people who have already endured five hundred and twenty-two years of suffocation and violations? My concern is with not allowing the white man to erase our culture, with not allowing the school to erase our culture. I, as a teacher, have to think a great deal about what I want to do with interculturality. If interculturality is a place of respect, sometimes when we want to respect too much or want to cure a person too quickly, we end up giving an extra dose of medicine and it ends up killing. In this sense, interculturality cannot be forced.

When I think about interculturality, I understand that it is important, a necessary good, but the question is how to build

this concept collectively within the school. How are we going to build this dialogically and collectively? For there to be interculturality there have to be two cultures, and when they meet, what will happen? They have to dialogue. In this dialogue, to what extent can the other culture have my knowledge? And to what extent can I have knowledge of the other culture?

If it is not built in a respectful, dialogical, and collective manner, it will continue to be a hierarchical, unequal process with many impacts on Indigenous peoples. From this perspective, the distrust our peoples feel toward interculturality can be understood, since the karaí worldview is not confluent with the native Kaiowá and Guarani cosmoperception; on the contrary, they are opposed. The quilombola intellectual Nêgo Bispo warns that “confluence is the law that governs the relationship of coexistence among the elements of nature and teaches us that not everything that comes together mixes” (SANTOS, 2015, p. 87).

In this same sense, the Indigenous intellectual of the Kaingang people, in his doctoral thesis, reflects that “the white man thinks of education as the best job, high wages, and understands nature as merchandise” (EMILIANO, 2020). Thus, the limitations of the white intercultural model are questioned by us, the Kaiowá and Guarani. To think of interculturality from the community base and from the valuing of traditional knowledge, it is necessary to say clearly that there is knowledge that we do not want to share with the karaí.

We do not want to show all our secrets of spiritual technology; this is a memory that the guardians, the elders of my people, both men and women, kept for a whole lifetime so that white people would not usurp it. What we want to share with the karaí are some aspects of mutual learning about coexistence with nature, the relationship with the cultivated field and how

we build a cultivated field, what the methodology of our people's traditional cultivated field is like, and what it means to be sustainable from our point of view. This we can share so that white people can learn and rethink their way of being and living.

We can also listen to what the methodology of white people is like in their fields. We can learn what the white man thinks he does right and what may seem wrong to us. This is dialogue; we do not accept imposition. We can discuss how and why white people destroy the land, and also see how they work the land. For example, to recover a territory, let us discuss how the Kaiowá and Guaraní reclaim territory and seek to restore the life of the land. Let us think together about how to restore and keep the environment healthy. Let us observe how the white man restores the environment, or whether he only causes damage. Let us reflect on why they use that fertilizer and why we use this one. These are important points for thinking about interculturality.

Another question relates to a point already raised in the text: so how do we go about this horizontal dialogue? On the premise that not everything can be intercultural. My fear is that our studies may open gaps that further impact our ways of living. Will the school be able to keep our language alive for another five hundred years? Keep our culture alive for another five hundred years? Will the school, through interculturality, manage to do this? So I remain quite concerned, but I believe in fair and respectful dialogue.

In contrast to intercultural discourses, we, Indigenous peoples, desire an education that is liberating, that emancipates, that is in keeping with our life, our culture, our spirituality, and our histories and trajectories as peoples. It is in this respect that dimensions of our political struggle are also inserted. This process involves reflecting on how peoples decide the themes and matters involved in the dynamics of education. Hence the

importance of thinking about our own politics, since it presupposes the condition for a teaching-learning process appropriate to our sociocultural points of view.

This differentiated education is a longstanding agenda and demand of the Indigenous Movement, and among the Kaiowá and Guaraní it emerges with the Movement of Indigenous Women and Men Teachers (MPGK), as a space of continuous training and political action, premised on the struggle for the right to a different kind of training, one that values traditional knowledge.

This movement, which operates from within Indigenous school education, has strengthened the emergence of new Indigenous leaders and teachers with a new Kaiowá and Guaraní identity, based on the reclaiming of traditional cultural values and the knowledge of other cultures, in a critical and reflective manner, as the Kaiowá researcher Eliel Benites explains:

These are contexts of deconstruction and reconstruction of values and traditional identities, spaces of continuous training, in which the traditional Kaiowá and Guaraní way of being is articulated with new postures, along with the construction of the strategies necessary for political confrontation, with a view to realizing the projects and dreams of Indigenous teachers (BENITES, 2014, p. 18-19).

Our education is born of the community and prioritizes our own historical, geographical, and sociological processes, our territorial struggles, and our own knowledge. Political self-determination contributes to this end, to our managing our own education ourselves, selecting the kinds of knowledge that should be built and shared in community schools. In this way, starting from ourselves, the school and another, possible interculturality can become a reflective space and action

grounded in Kaiowá and Guaraní values. From this, I want to set down a marker that Indigenous knowledge and sciences are fundamental to another way of thinking about education and to putting an end to the Eurocentric colonization of knowledge, as set out in a text of my own authorship:

With this, I want to demonstrate that our traditional knowledge is capable of bringing answers to many of the questions that society of today requires, for it is important to understand that we share in this society; we are all on the same road, that is, we are part of the same universe and must care for it (PERALTA, 2017, p. 9)

For our relative Célia Xakriabá, thinking about interculturality with these meanings allows us to revisit our educational practices, not in a superficial and artificial way, but in an engaged way, experiencing the culture of other subjects, in interaction:

It is no longer fitting to work with a curricular thinking such as “disciplinization”; we need, on the contrary, to question this model of uniformization, which makes us always take as our starting point segmentation, in an expectation (which often does not come true) of reaching the whole. In indigenizing educational practices, the proposal is the opposite: the invitation is to start from the whole, from those that are our deep roots, to arrive at the small details, these, thought of always as practices that lead us to act in the world in an active, creative, and subversive way whenever necessary (CORREA, 2018, p. 58).

And this process can only be built in a horizontal and communitarian way, in which we take ownership of the schools located in our territories, based on our own ways of reclaiming this space. At the same time, it opens up paths that break with the centralism and hierarchy that has always characterized institutional and bureaucratic spaces. From this perspective, the construction of knowledge is a process elaborated on the ground of the village, drawing on the theoretical-methodological

potential of communities and the praxis of collective subjects who question the colonizing role imposed by institutions.

In this way, Indigenous thought and its counter-hegemonic practices sow an interculturality that recognizes and values the diversity of epistemologies and the multiplicity of worlds and forms of knowledge as an emancipatory instrument of discourse and praxis, as pointed out by the author Jorge Viaña (2009).

It is a fact that this entire process has been built through great struggle, for we know that in these five hundred and twenty-two years, everything that the Original Peoples have reclaimed and won as original rights came through much resistance, and not because the State was willing to respect the Original Peoples. We know it is a long journey, but we know that a territorialized education is the key to strengthening our peoples and communities, transforming educational spaces.

As the author Célia Xakriabá teaches us, thinking about a territorialized education means starting from interaction with the territory, and not “merely adding the knowledge produced in the territory into the school, in such a way that this interaction is committed, above all, to the question of the territory, and is operated only from within it” (CORREA, 2018, p. 166).

Other Possible Experiences for a Territorialized and Community-Based Education

For us, Original Peoples, in the multiplicity of peoples that we are, education needs to be built from within our own communities, in the territories where we live, and with the collective agendas and strategies that strengthen our self-determination and educational autonomy. That is why we fight for a differentiated and intercultural education, as discussed earlier, one that truly values horizontal dialogue and our

traditional knowledge. It is this movement that allows for the gradual realization of a territorialized education, sustained by the original matrix and by the ancestral struggle to defend our wisdoms, our collectivities, and our ways of thinking/acting in the world.

In parallel with Indigenous school education, we, the Kaiowá and Guarani, have also built other experiences in our communities, proposing other educational processes aimed at strengthening collectivity and traditional knowledge. These spaces are not institutional spaces, but our own spaces, raised up by the community itself, constituting a dynamic of education that is an alternative to the intercultural model implemented by the State. These experiences take up once more the strengthening of our own ways of organizing and propose an interculturality conceived from our own way of being and living.

These proposals do not present themselves as an immediate solution to all the problems caused by the *karaí*, but rather are expressed as a path for thinking about new possibilities for the construction of knowledge in community. They are experiences of Indigenous, original education that drive individual and collective emancipation.

Among our Kaiowá and Guarani people, one of the important experiences takes place in the *tekoha* Panambizinho, in the sacred space of Xiru Karai, known as an experimental village-school, built since 2010. In this space we combine the management of diverse plants, diversifying and keeping together various cultivated species, in processes grounded in what I call spiritual technology, valuing our knowledge, since the Kaiowá and Guarani are traditionally farmers and have always produced rich gardens and fields, which even fed many of the colonizers (PERALTA, 2017).

The authors Monfort and Gislotti (2020) classify these community experiences as actions built from ancestral knowledge, and from Kaiowá and Guarani practices and knowledge, as spheres of potential for processes of ecological restoration, fundamental to territorial struggles and to new ways of knowing-and-doing education and politics. The energies of Kaiowá and Guarani pedagogy are related to the place where one lives and the place where one is, opening new horizons for thinking about collective paths of emancipation.

The project still has little support from Indigenous School Education, but it is a fundamental project for Kaiowá and Guarani pedagogy, and one that could make a great contribution to the schools located in the villages. Although Xiru Karaí is different from Indigenous School Education, the school institution has much to learn from the autonomous spaces that exist in the community and should value dialogue between these experiences. The school must be open to strengthening the community and the struggle of the people themselves, and not be at the service of a system that has always oppressed the Original Peoples.

Another experience that emerges among us, Kaiowá and Guarani, is the community space Kurundua, in the Jaguapiru village, one of the villages that make up the Dourados Indigenous Reserve. The Kurundua space, built from the community's political self-determination, was organized by a Ñandesy and a Ñanderu as a community space aimed at strengthening traditional knowledge through sharing between different generations.

The territorial organization of the Indigenous Reserves imposed a broad process of precarization within an extremely reduced space, contrary to the possibility of living well, of *bem viver*. Resisting this, one of the principles of this community

space is to strengthen collectivity through the Ñanderu and Ñandesy, even amid the difficulties within the Indigenous Reserve.

Another important experience is the Native Seedling Nursery of the Ñandejara Pólo Municipal Indigenous School, in the Teý'ikuê village, in the municipality of Caarapó, which began its activities in 1997, with the proposal of producing native seedlings for the restoration of springs and forests. The project is linked to the Experimental Unit, which began its activities in 2001 for the management of cultivation practices, animal raising, and the conservation of the region's microwatersheds, based on Kaiowá and Guaraní knowledge, with a view to the agroecological and agroforestry system, as demonstrated by Professor Lídio Ramires (2016).

We believe that restoring our ways of sharing knowledge in order to defend the territory and build new educational experiences stands in opposition to state policy, which aims to maintain the order of the karaí and their top-down interculturality. Thus, these experiences spring from Kaiowá and Guaraní struggles, in the face of the difficulties of territorialization caused by agribusiness, which constantly tries to colonize our ancestral lands.

I believe it is possible to think about interculturality on the ground of the community, in such a way that the school engages in dialogue with and learns from other pedagogical experiences and our own spaces, which make possible a community education built from traditional knowledge and practices, and which open up other paths for interculturality outside of the asymmetrical interculturality brought by the karaí, in which the interests of the State and the colonizers prevail.

In this way, thinking about an education centered on theories and practices that are specifically our own is indispensable for the educational process to succeed in Indigenous school institutions and in other educational spaces within the communities. It is this relationship that guides the struggle for an education that is truly ours, in which the pedagogical principle of 'walking while asking questions,' together with the original knowledge and practices of the peoples, wrests control over teaching and learning in Indigenous schools from the hands of the State.

What I propose to consider here as Intercultural Education is that this construction be grounded in cosmology, in the socio-territorial and ecological relations that arise through traditional knowledge, as well as in respect for our way of life. These are the elements that strengthen the struggle against the monoculture of the mind and that recreate community spaces in defense of life and of territories, seeking the construction of knowledge for life and for *bem viver*.



Interculturality does not necessarily need to involve Western science, that of the *karái*, the kind that does not converge with and belittles other forms of knowledge. In this way, I conclude by proposing that interculturality be built and grounded in

dialogues with other cultures, beyond the culture white culture of the colonizer. May it be grounded in community exchange between our educational spaces and the knowledge of other traditional peoples, such as the quilombola people, the riverine communities, the Pantanal peoples, the fishing communities, in short, the countless peoples of different territories and territorialities. These confluences can bring about another interculturality, different from the one that involves the karaí.

Final Reflections

In this book, I, Anastácio Peralta of the Kaiowá people, who since my childhood have fought for survival, bring in my own history and in the history of my people the desire for us to be protagonists and sovereign, as we already were in the past, with regard to food, territorial, and spiritual sovereignty.

In these discussions, I sought to bring forward the question of Kaiowá and Guarani spirituality and sustainability existing in the beings of nature, so that future generations may come to recognize the empirical values in the struggle for land and for our own spirituality, which finds itself weakened.

More specifically, I sought to focus my efforts on discussing and reflecting on our Kaiowá and Guarani sustainability, which is grounded in our spiritual technology, in the sense of raising ideas and examples that point to paths for sustaining all the beings of planet Earth.

In dialogue with, and learning from, the elder women and elder men of my people, I concluded that our spirituality and our differentiated relationship with all beings are a type of technology quite different from the technology of white people. Our technology aims at the permanence of life in all its exuberant diversity, while the technology of white people wants to homogenize everything, wants to make what is diverse become a single thing.

In light of this, I believe that the *kokwe* (traditional cultivated field) is the model to be developed so that, little by little, we can restore the soil, so as to have an abundant production, free of agrottoxins and respectful of all the beings who live alongside us. In this way, we will be able to achieve our

sustainability, a dignified and full life in the Kaiowá and Guarani way of living.

I understand that we are nature itself, and in this way we are capable of responding to all the wounds inflicted on Mother Earth, who possesses the power to reconstitute herself, provided that we care for her and give her time to recover. For this, the technology used by the Kaiowá and Guarani people, of making small fields in varied locations, leaving part of the land to rest, can, over the years, resolve soil compaction and degradation.

The great battle we face is that the *karaí* want to modify everything in nature, causing irreversible harm to us, since modified seeds and the use of agrottoxins are killing our Mother and all the spirits who live here and who give us life. They even want to modify our culture, our education, our way of existing in the world.

Nature is at its limit, according to scientists and religious figures of the most diverse beliefs, which is why eco-spirituality is already being considered. This is why the *rezadores* and *rezadoras* (prayer leaders) are fundamental, since they use their knowledge and their spiritual technologies for preparing the soil, baptizing the seeds, and planting and harvesting food.

Thus, by maintaining the sacred rituals of our people, we put into practice what I understand as spiritual technology, understanding that everything is interconnected and in harmony with the cosmos. In this way we are giving the world sustainable answers, leading people to take ownership of their own knowledge and put it into practice. This movement will free us from the great producers of death.

They stole our lands, destroyed nature, polluted our rivers, stained our ground with the blood of my people. But they were

not able to destroy our language, our prayer, our culture, our history, our resistance, and our hope.

And today, inspired by this research, I am involving the tekoha Panambizinho, together with allies who work in defense of Mother Earth, in an agroecological and agroforestry experiment, where the goal is to restore the environment and perpetuate the sacred beings, so that people may have a place where they can nourish the spirit and the hope for a better world. Long live the struggle of the Kaiowá and Guarani! Long live Teko Porã!

#DEMARCATIION NOW!

Pe'ẽ xe mbovy'a eterei... Anastacio Peralta, February 2022.

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Appendices

Appendix 1: Projects Developed in the Panambizinho Indigenous Land

Hygiene kit with laundry and FUNASA (National Foundation for water facilities Sanitary Assistance) Literacy project for MovaBrasil Project, Federal, adults State and Municipal Governments Delivery of basic food baskets FUNAI, State Government Health post with agents Federal, Municipal Government and community Non-Governmental Organization Kaiowá Mission Horse and cart Project for the Labor Foundation (FUNTRAB) Indigenous people Secretariat of Agriculture of Mato Grosso do Sul Farming Plot Project Dr. Rubens de Almeida Collective fields Padre Jorge Young Apprentice Project UFGD and Municipal Government of Dourados Environmental restoration Municipal Government of Dourados, project linked to the school Municipal Secretariat of Education Kua'agwy Renuã Forest Flourishing (Semed), Agriculture and UFGD Bakery Project PROEXT/UFGD and Municipal School Paí Chiquito-Chiquito Pedro Indigenous [School] Manicure Project CRAS/SISTEMASS – income generation courses Handicraft-Making Project CRAS/SISTEMASS – income generation courses Hammock production workshops Sisters of the Most Holy Trinity, in the person of Sister Elisa Biscola Cassava reuse workshop CRAS/SISTEMASS – income generation courses Banana reuse workshop CRAS/SISTEMASS – income generation courses

Soup kitchen for children and the elderly CRAS/SISTEMASS – income generation courses CIMI Ombudsman, aimed at CIMI, through the missionary Geraldo learning about the reality experienced over almost ten years of land reclamation by Augusto and Maria Leda Yvy Akãndiré Project Embassy of the Netherlands, Association Douradense Indigenous [Association] Guarani, Terena and Kaiowá (Assind) JOINPA Sports Project: Indigenous City Council, Municipal Government Games of Panambizinho. of Dourados Health Agent Reginaldo's Project, who requested support from City Councilman Elias Ischy Food and Nutritional Sustainability Project: Manos Unidas, CIMI Tree-planted yards Entrekokue, Mbo'eroy Kokue'ie Paí Municipal Indigenous School Ethnomathematics: Curricular Practices Experienced at Paí Chiquito Chiquito Pedro Geo-agroecological Stoves and fields Project United Nations Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO), UNDP, Emergency Fund International of

the United Nations for Children (UNICEF), Organization Pan-American Health (PAHO) and International Labor Organization (ILO) Vegetable Garden Project Education and Health. Institutional Scholarship Program for Arnaldo, Misael, Reginaldo and Teaching Initiation Samuel (PIBID) Crossed Glances Images of Life, with support from CIMI/MS Prayer House Construction Project Nelson Concianza Indigenous Cultural Association of Producers (ASCURI) Source: Prepared by the author.